

The background features a large, glowing blue clock face with Roman numerals. Inside the clock face is a silhouette of a person in a meditative pose, surrounded by a bright, multi-colored aura that radiates outwards. The overall color scheme is dominated by blue and green tones.

Meditation

24x7

Acharya Prashant



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1.

What is meditation?



nirantarābhyāsavaśāttaditthaṃ pakvaṃ mano brahmaṇi līyate yadā tadā
samādhiḥ savikalpavarjitaḥ svato'dvayānandarasānubhāvakaḥ

Just as gold, by thorough heating in fire, gives up its impurities and gains its own lustre, so too the mind through meditation sheds its impurities of Sattva, Rajas, and Tamas, and attains the nature of Brahman.

~ Vivekachudamani, Verse 362



Questioner (Q): What is meditation? Is meditation about understanding? What is meant by purifying the mind through meditation? The practice of meditation is mentioned at many places. What is this practice about? Is there any methodless method to attain the unchanged understanding or meditative state?

Acharya Prashant (AP): I will repeat the verse.

“Just as gold, by thorough heating in fire, gives up its impurities and gains its own lustre, so too the mind through meditation sheds its impurities of *Sattva*, *Rajas*, and *Tamas*, and attains the nature of *Brahman*.”

The question is about meditation. What is meditation? Is there any methodless method? Is meditation about understanding? Let's begin from what you already know of. You know of thought, right? You know of thought. So, begin with thought.

What is thought? There is you and there is the object you are thinking of, and there is a relation between you and that object. You don't just think of anything. You define the object you are thinking of. The object that you

think of depends on you, and the relationship is always of either fear or greed.

That which you are either wants or repels. That which you are is either greedy or afraid. He knows no other state. That is thought: you want something.

What is meditation, then? Meditation is when you want the Highest alone. Meditation is when you are fed up of looking at the small. Meditation is when you look at the small and you say that “If this is all that I can look at, then it cannot be small; it has to be very, very large.”

Meditation is when nothing but the Truth is, therefore, the object you aim at.

“I want the Truth.” You can say your sole focus, then, is the Truth. But the Truth, as we know, is not something to be thought of, because one is too small to think of the Truth. Therefore, if one stubbornly insists that nothing but the Truth is to be known, then either one fails or one bursts.

Please understand. There is a balloon; it can only hold a limited quantity, a limited volume of air. You try to inflate it beyond its permissible limit; either you will fail in inflating it and the balloon won’t grow beyond a particular size, or the balloon would burst. Meditation is the bursting of the balloon. The balloon is saying, “I want to hold the infinite. I want to hold the sky. Just holding a little bit of air is no fun. I want to hold the sky.” So, the balloon bursts.

So, meditation is a special kind of thought in which the thinker bursts, because the thinker is trying to achieve that which cannot be achieved. You are aiming at that which cannot be aimed at, which is *alakha* (beyond comprehension, invisible). When you are aiming at the deep, deep Truth, then your faculty keeps becoming subtler and subtler and finer and finer, and ultimately, it just disappears. This disappearance is meditation.

You are looking at something and you are contented with the looks, you are contented with the form, you are contented with the label—then meditation is not for you. Meditation is when you look and you are not contented. You say you want more. You say, “It is just not what it appears to be.” You want to be sharper, you want to be finer.

You are hungry and you don’t want to suppress your hunger. You express the hunger. Boldly, you move towards the danger area, the abyss, and you know that it is dangerous, mortally dangerous, but still, there is

something that calls you, lures you. You keep moving, and then you are no more. That's meditation.

Therefore, meditation is not for those who are easily satisfied. And therefore, meditation is not for those who just want to practice methods.

Meditation is for those who have a taste for the mystical.

Meditation is for those who have a knack for the unknowable.

Unless you are a little crazy, unless you are a little off-center, a little mad by worldly standards, meditation is not for you.

The world looks at something and says, "This is how it is; its definition has already been supplied to me. A woman is a woman, a man is a man, a sunset is a sunset, a sunrise is a sunrise, a lake is a lake, a vehicle is a vehicle, a job is a job, a kid is a kid, a cub is a cub." Meditation is for the eccentric ones, who say, "No, a kid is not just a kid. There is something within that tells me that the kid..." And silence. That is meditation.

And therefore, there can be no one method of meditation, because the universe is always all around you, so say your senses.

Meditation is the honest way of looking at the universe, and that includes yourself. When you are honestly looking at anything, you are meditating. When you are committed to the Truth, then you are meditating.

And when you say that even the half-truths and lies are acceptable, then it is beyond you to meditate. Meditation is for the daring ones, who say that "We are prepared to die, we are prepared to disappear, but we will not accept the stories. We want to go into the deep, dark cave and figure out for ourselves what lies within."

Entering the cave is sure shot death. But then, there are some crazy ones who do meditation.



2.

What is Vipassana meditation?



Questioner (Q): What is Vipassana? What does it mean to watch the breath?

Acharya Prashant (AP): That which you call Vipassana today is a very recent phenomenon. They claim that it comes from the Buddha; actually, it does not. The stream flowing from Buddha got extinct around the 8th or 10th century AD. This modern Vipassana came up in Burma just around a 100 years back, and this is not what the Buddha taught. It is very much an improvised thing.

If you could really look, first of all you would look into what you are doing right now. Why would you be someone who has the capacity to look at something as subtle as the breath, and yet he is not able to look at something as gross as his actions?

It is about looking, right? Observing, Vipassana; observing rightly. The breath is subtle, actions are so loud.

If you could look, what is it that you would first of all look at? Your actions. And if you are able to directly look at your actions, do you really need to look at the breath or this or that?

See how you are living; that's all.

Obviously, seeing is important. But what to see? Breath? There is nothing wrong with the breath! Why are you watching the breath? Or maybe watching the breath is a convenient way to avoid watching that which really needs to be watched.

You need to watch your behavior towards your wife. Instead of that, you are watching your breath. Nice trick. Smart chap!

You need to watch how greedy you are towards your customers and how exploitative you are towards your employees. And instead of that, you are watching your breath. Nice, pretty nice!

You need to watch your restlessness when you are waiting at the traffic signal—and it is so evident, it is observable. Look at the tension in your calves. See how you are constantly pushing at the clutch pedal or the

accelerator even though you fully well know that the car is in neutral. There are forty more seconds to go before it goes green, and you see how your legs are twitching, and you are fiddling with the controls? The moment it goes green, you honk!

Now, is that not observable? Then what is all this drama about watching the breath, observing the breath? Can't you observe the thousand things that you are continuously doing? But probably you want to, as I said, avoid watching your real life, your day-to-day life.

So, you go for a ten-day Vipassana retreat. Ten days of watching the breath, and then you can come out with a certificate that helps the inner lie. "I am spiritual. Now I can go back to my shop and continue adulterating and looting!"

You won't observe the face of the goat or the chicken being slaughtered for your food in front of your eyes. Do you observe that? No, that is something you stubbornly want to avoid observing—but you want to observe your breath. How exotic. Seriously spiritual!

If you want to observe, look into the eyes of the bird being slaughtered for your taste buds. No, but all these teachers won't tell you that. They say, "Observation means, you know, breath, breath..." (*Makes pompous gestures with a solemn face*)

If you want to observe, observe the eyes of the cow being milked for your cheese. Go observe. That is far more real.

You want to observe? Observe your face after freshly receiving a bashing from your boss. Retire to the washroom—as you anyway do—having been spanked by your boss, and there honestly look into the mirror and observe your face. That is Vipassana.

Observation is great, and yes, the Buddha did teach the observation. But observe *what*?

Q: So, all these meditation techniques of watching and observing the breath are best to be avoided?

AP: Observe, but observe the real thing. I am repeating this.

Q: There are many teachers who say that watching the breath is the real thing.

AP: We don't want to talk about them; we have very little time. Should we spend this time talking about charlatans? And I don't even want to accuse them; they themselves are misled. Maybe they never had a teacher who could tell them a few nuanced things.

They are just following the tradition. Their guru was observing the breath, so was his guru, and so they have now opened a shop and all with all these things happening. And once you have been following a tradition, it becomes very difficult for you to break away.

Q: Because it becomes a part of you.

AP: It becomes a part of you, and what would you tell yourself? That all this while you have been a fool? Not only have you been a fool; your guru and his guru have been a fool. It becomes very humiliating to accept this.

Q: But it has to be done?

AP: It has to be done. And then one needs compassion; one needs to say, "After all, they too are mortals, and mortals do make mistakes."

Mistakes don't need to be prolonged, stretched. Mistakes need to be rectified.

Q: When we do meditation techniques like dynamic meditation, it certainly feels good.

AP: They have a certain value. They introduce you to something beyond yourself. But that is a mere introduction. Beyond that there has to be intimacy, right? When you are talking of love, does introduction suffice? Beyond introduction you need intimacy. Where is the intimacy?

All techniques just give you a glimpse of something. They give you a glimpse so that you fall in love with the glimpse, and then you demand more. You *must* demand more.

But what if you get satisfied with the glimpse? What if the glimpse itself becomes a competitor, a substitute of the real thing?

That's how wicked we can be. You were given a glimpse so that you now take a few extra steps to move into the land of the unknown, the Beloved. But instead of that, you get the glimpse and then you retreat, and when you again feel restless, you again take the glimpse, and then you again retreat into your habitual world, and then you again feel restless and you take the glimpse. That's how man misuses methods of meditation.

So, when you are feeling very uneasy within, you use the dynamic method, and then you return to your old world. That is not good. That is not what the creators of these techniques wanted.

If you are talking of dynamic meditation, Osho himself categorically said so many times that ultimately you have to give up all methods. His favorite analogy was: "Once the river has been crossed, you cannot keep sitting in the boat."

Q: So, *sādhana* has to evolve. It cannot be a repetition...

AP: Yes, surely. Wonderful.

Q: ...because Truth itself is a living thing.

AP: No, these are Krishnamurti's words: "Truth is a living thing."

Sādhana has to keep evolving because *you* are at different points in your journey. So, your movement, your strategy, your self, all are continuously changing. One thing that was suitable a year back will no more be suitable a year later if you have really advanced. You cannot give class six textbooks to a class eight student, can you? It is as commonsensical as that.

Q: How do we find out those extra steps to be taken after trying techniques of meditation?

AP: When you were in class twelfth and you were chasing her, how did you know what to do next? How did you know? You found out. In love, one finds out.

You just got a glimpse of her in the school fest, and she is from some other school, some other class, but you found out everything—including the name of her ex doggy! You figured out everything flat in two days, and now you are asking, "Having got a glimpse, how do I proceed further?"

Where is love?

Q: Does it come down to the thirst of it?

AP: Obviously. Everything comes down to that, including this. Why else are you here?



3.

Strange sounds and thoughts during meditation

(Rishikesh, 2020)



Questioner (Q): I have a few questions about my practice. When I notice thoughts arising or hear sounds in meditation, I ask, “To whom is this arising?” and sometimes they will just disappear, they will not bother me.

So, is the practice really that simple, that whenever I notice these I just witness them and enquire to whom they are arising?

Also, some thoughts and some sounds have more of an attraction to them. I am pulled towards some of them, and some of them I want to reject. What should I do?

Acharya Prashant (AP): Who is noticing all this? Who is the questioner? So, when you ask, “To whom are these sounds and noises?” the answer is obvious. These sounds and noises are to the questioner.

Can you question something without noticing it? If you don’t even notice the sound, would you question who is the recipient of the sound, who is receiving or paying attention to the sound?

So, a better practice would probably be to ask, “Why does the sound matter to me at all?” If you ask, “To whom are these sounds?” then the answer will not take you very far, because the answer is obvious. These sounds are to the questioner, nobody else. The incident of asking the question itself reveals the one who is cognizant of those sounds.

So, that matter is settled. Now we come to the next question.

There are a variety of sounds always entering my sensory space, are there not? Why do I feel attracted to or charmed by or offended by a few of them, and why are a few others not significant to me? That's the question that will tell you something about the nature of your mind, the constitution of your inner *prakriti* (nature). And this knowledge helps.

Ego that starts knowing itself does not remain charmed by itself for too long.

A point might come when no sound matters so much to you that it pushes you to ask, "From where is the sound? To whom is the sound?" because even asking these questions is some kind of a chore, an unnecessary activity. This will not allow you to fully rest. You always have an agenda at hand. The moment the sound comes, you have to be vigilant and ask, "To whom is the sound?" and all those things.

Far better is to not be alive to the sound at all. Let the ears receive the sound, let the mind and the memory process the sound. You keep sleeping in your cozy bed. That's the utter inner relaxation that spirituality is all about. Let all the action smoothly, resistancelessly happen on the outside; within, you remain in your nature, and your nature is of relaxation.

Even if the mind is troubled, let the trouble remain on the periphery of the mind. The center of the mind should be carefree as ever.

Q: How do you get to that place?

AP: By having some respect and love for relaxation. If you keep respecting all the wrong things, how will you ever fall in love with restfulness?

Therefore, even here, the process must be of negation. See who are the ones you accord value to. See what is it that you respect in your daily life. And if you are respecting all the sources and agents of trouble and worry and anxiety, then how will you ever respect the right one?

And the right one is a bit finicky on this count. The right one says, "I will have all your respect, or nothing. You cannot give me divided attention." It is not for nothing that he is called the Absolute. What does 'absolute' mean? Total.

So, he says, "You cannot get away with this. Forty types of falsenesses you respect from your morning till evening. Look at your daily life, pay attention, and then you put me as forty-first in the queue?"

You say, "I respect Truth *as well*. I respect peace *as well*." This won't do. You cannot respect Truth 'as well'.

If Truth is to be respected, if peace is to be loved, that love has to be unconditional and absolute, totally undivided, unfragmented, reserved only for the One.

Q: What were the forty falsehoods you referred to?

AP: You have to look into your daily life. For example, if you cannot find a hundred rupee note on the table and you allow yourself to go berserk over the event, then see what is it that you respect.

Somebody comes and just pushes against your shoulder—on the streets of Rishikesh it is quite possible—and you allow yourself to be offended by that, and you chase that person, and you want to give it back to him in double the quantity. Then you have declared the one you love: you love agitation, you love street fights.

Now, with the same kind of mind, how will you love peace?

So, that's why spirituality definitely has to be a 24/7 occupation. You have to constantly see what you are doing, not police yourself.

Q: What is the difference?

AP: In policing, you want a particular kind of standard behavior, and that behavior has been determined in advance.

You have to very passively just watch, and that watching is not an act. You don't have to add it to your to-do list. It happens on its own.

You just have to, therefore, not watch but actually acknowledge. The watching is happening. It is the acknowledgment that remains missing.

We know what we do, don't we? It's not that we are so ignorant about ourselves. We know what is going on. What we lack, usually, is the honesty to acknowledge it. We give colorful names to our behaviors and attitudes. We do not call a nail a nail and a spade a spade.

For example, if there is jealousy, outright naked jealousy, we might choose to call it ambition. And that doesn't help, right?

Jealousy has to be called as jealousy.

Insecurity has to be called as insecurity, not future planning.

Lust has to be called as lust, not love.

It is in these names that we have totally deceived ourselves and others as well.

Q: So, if I see someone and I notice that lust arises, I should just acknowledge that I am feeling lustful and...

AP: Smile. That's the nature of the inner animal. When you watch a bull chasing a cow, what do you do? You don't become a participant in the act, do you? You let the bull chase the cow, and you smile and you say, "That's the nature of the animal."

Similarly, you have to acknowledge that there exists the bull within, and that is enough. You don't have to police the bull after that.



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4.

Myths about meditation

(Advait Bodhsthal, 2020)



Questioner (Q): One of the popular beliefs about meditation is that it makes the mind stop and you will not have any thoughts. A lot of the so-called gurus say that your mind should be completely blank, no thoughts, and if any thought comes that means you are doing it wrong.

That doesn't sound very correct to me. What is really meant by stilling the mind or quieting the mind?

Acharya Prashant (AP): The mind has to value stillness. That is called meditateness.

Mind, at every point, at every moment, is a choice. The choice on one side is restiveness, lack of rest. The choice on the other side is restfulness.

Then, what is meditation? To be in the right choice continuously, 24/7; that is meditation.

You cannot stop the movement of the mind. The mind is nothing but movement. You just have to ensure that it moves rightly; that is meditateness. And meditateness is that when, just by chance, there is no need for the mind to move, then you do not become uncomfortable and start forcing it to move.

When the mind is moving, it is moving in the right direction. When it is not moving, then it is not moving rightly. Because it is quite possible, be cautious, that there might be a need for the mind to move, and yet the mind is so lethargic, so ponderous, that it refuses to move. In fact, such a mind can even use the name of meditation to defend its inability or unwillingness to move, even though movement is the need of the moment.

When it is right, there has to be movement. When there is movement, the movement has to be in the right direction. When it is right, then there can be no movement. None of these is sacred on its own. None of these is a gospel truth on its own.

Should the mind keep moving? Not necessarily. Should the mind keep still? Not necessarily. Those who say that the mind must necessarily be still

are as much in darkness as those who are compulsive movers of the mind.

These are two extremes. On one hand, there are people addicted to mental activity. They become very uncomfortable if somehow the mind pauses even for a while. They cannot tolerate silence, they cannot tolerate rest or stillness. You must have met such people, sometimes in the mirror.

Heard of the phrase 'awkward silence'? How can silence be awkward? But we do find silence awkward many-a-times. It is because we are used to noise. This kind of a mind is unhealthy. At the same time, there are people who just have lost the ability to think, to reason. Theirs has become a dull and dead mind. It is not a welcome situation, obviously.

The mind must be perfectly capable of rapid movement when needed, and when it is not needed, then the mind must be equally comfortable in lazily sleeping with no trace of guilt. There is no need to move, so the mind is not needlessly hopping about, and when there is a need to move, the mind is lightning-quick. Both of these are included in meditateness. Do we get this?

Almost like a tennis player, a soccer player, a cricket player. Seen how still the batsman is when the ball is approaching him in his run-up? Then what is needed is the stillness of body, of mind as well. And the moment the batsman is able to read the ball, what does he do? He has to move with great agility. The ball is going to take a fraction of a second to reach him. The batsman must be nimble enough to adjust him beforehand. If he cannot adjust himself beforehand, then the opportunity is lost. He has failed the test.

So, you need to be still when you need to be still. You need to move when you need to move. And you must be adept at both. This is meditateness.

In either case, whether you are moving or you are still, what is the objective? The objective is peace, Truth, a final rest. You rest for the sake of a final rest, you move for the sake of a final rest, like a good traveler does, no? If the journey is long, do you ever move continuously without a break? No.

You move. What do you move for? You move for the destination. And then, sometimes, you take a break and you rest; now you are not moving. You are not moving for the sake of movement. You are not moving so that you may move properly, nimbly, speedily, when needed. That is meditateness.

It is devotion, another name for devotion, continuous devotion. Obviously, it cannot be a trick, a technique, a thing that you do mentally or physically. When you define meditation in those terms, then you pull it down to a very low level.

There are people who come up with questions like, “What happens during meditation?” Well, if you are not insane, then life. If you are insane, then you will have some insane experiences during meditation. Otherwise, meditation is life. Life is meditation. And if life is not meditation, then there is insanity. Do you get this?

As I speak to you, do I speak continuously? Is there an uninterrupted volley of words? That’s what, right?

You speak when needed. You don’t speak when not needed. You stop when needed. The objective is the same, whether you speak or you stop. What is the objective? The objective is clarity, the objective is light. This is meditateness.

Q: As I go about my day, I notice that there are always judgments about things, and oftentimes they are not positive. “This is dirty, that should be put away, he is doing this, this is unclean.” Do these thoughts go away in meditateness?

AP: You have to have *right* thoughts. You need to judge rightly. You need to ask yourself, “Is this the best thing, the only thing that I need to be judgmental on, or are there better things, more important things I reserve my judgment for?” Being judgmental is not a problem per se. The question is, firstly, what are you so involved in judging? Secondly, what is the criteria?

I am speaking to you and my mind is busy judging the quality of this hand towel. I mean, is this the right thing to be focusing on at this moment? Secondly, how do I judge whether this thing is proper? What is the criteria? The brightness, the number of times it has gone through the laundry, how expensive it looks and feels? How exactly do I judge?

So, be a better judge. That is meditateness: keeping your arrow in the right direction irrespective of where you stand. If you are standing on the dimension of judgment, be a better judge. If you must think, then be a better thinker. If you cannot avoid company, find a better company.

Irrespective of where you stand and what you are doing and what your *prakritik* configuration is making you do, do it in a better way. Point towards greatness all the time. Can’t you be a great judge?

Q: I like what you said, “Be a great judge.” But the thought that comes to me is, how do I know it is not my ego trying to be superior and saying, “Oh, I am a great judge”?

AP: That is exactly what we have to do to the ego: make it a great ego. How else do you kill the ego? By making it great.

Q: So, what is the criteria for the great?

AP: You know when things are petty. How did you know that it is petty to be talking of the towel now?

Q: I just knew.

AP: You just knew because here the case is simpler, more obvious. In other cases, if you apply yourself, you do not get carried away, you will equally well know.

It is very obvious that it is petty of me to be talking of the towel right now. In other moments of the day as well, you will realize. Just ask yourself, “Is this the most important thing I must do?”

“I have come to this place called BodhSthal—and I am judging the rabbits!” And you can judge the rabbits, you know. One of them is a little villain; two of them are, I mean, you could use the choicest words for them.

And here you are, standing and judging them. Are you here for the rabbits, really? Why are you judging the rabbits? And if you must judge the rabbits, judge from a higher position, and then another, and then another. Keep elevating yourself.

Q: This makes sense. I guess what comes to me now—maybe from the fake guru stuff I have been exposed to—is the sense of that it is all subjective, everyone has got a different perspective.

AP: But then, that subjectivity is life. There is nothing but that.

Remember that we are nothing but the ego. You cannot just jump out of your ego. You have to travel with this ego to that point where it reaches, meets its climax. That’s what I am calling greatness.

You cannot say, “Don’t be judgmental.” Even that is a piece of judgment, right? If you can see, when you say, “Don’t be judgmental,” are you not being judgmental this very moment?

So, you cannot just drop the ego. You *are* the ego. You can’t even leap out of your skin. How will you leap out of the ego? So, you have to remember that that which you are *itself* has to be elevated, elevated, elevated, and if you can elevate it high enough, then you have transcended.

Transcendence does not really mean a change of dimension. Here I am contradicting myself. Sufficient change in degree, honest change in degree, can precipitate a change in dimension.

So, you keep elevating yourself, elevating yourself, elevating yourself, and at one point you find that your very DNA has changed. Not literally, but you understand what I am saying. You are no more the same species; it just happens.

Know where you stand. Know what your *prakritik* tendencies are, and that's the way you have to take.

If *Prakriti* (physical nature) has made you in a way where jealousy is prominent, then you have to use the same jealousy as your way. You have to be a better jealous person. Your jealousy has to be directed towards a higher object.

If yours is the way of inertness, as some people are—you want to provoke them, excite them, they won't get excited, and they don't really achieve much because they don't really react much—then they have to use that particular personality trait as their way.

There are people who are insecure. You have to use this insecurity itself as your tool. Why? Not because it is quite smart to do that, but because there is no other way.

We are not saying that it is a very, very clever trick to use your insecurity as your technique, no. But the thing is, you *are* insecure. A lot of it is in your genes. And some people are genetically more insecure than the others. What do they do? Dynamite their body? Substitute their DNA? They can't do that. So, what do you do, then?

Whatsoever has been given to you has to be utilized in the service of the highest, irrespective of what you have been given. If you have been given strength, use strength. If you have been given weakness, use weakness.

“He was a greatly weak person.” No, that does not mean that he was a very weak person; that does not mean that you are great *among* the weak ones. You have to be *greatly* weak; weak, yet great. You have to take your weakness towards greatness. Riding on your weakness, you move towards greatness. So, that door is, then, open for everyone. It's just that, to that door, a thousand different paths come. There are as many paths as there are people. Your very personality is the method, and therefore no one method can be applicable to all. What will work for you, will not work for her.

So, don't ever be disappointed. Never say that "I do not have the aptitude or the acuity that a Krishna had or a Buddha had. I do not have that, so how do I make it?" No.

You have what you have, and that is sufficient.

On one hand, you have to kind of despise yourself. As Jesus said, "Unless you hate yourself, your life, your father, your mother, your friends, you cannot come to me." On one hand, you have to be very disdainful towards yourself. On the other hand, you have to know that you are all you have got. You don't have anything else. You are all you have.

Like somebody in the middle of a jungle, stuck in his old car. What do you do? Set the car to fire? What do you do? Yeah, you can curse and kick the car as much as you want, but ultimately it's the car that will get you out of the jungle.

So, that's us, the person stuck in the jungle, and that's us, the car you are stuck with. We are both, the person and the car.

And believe me, we seriously are a very outdated, shabby, dilapidated specimen of a car; but that's all that we have. Stuck there, no point dreaming of brand new SUVs and such things. That rusty piece of metal is all that you have. This rusty piece of metal is all that we have. Curse it? Alright. And having cursed it to your heart's satisfaction, now use it. Curse it every day, use it every day.

Yours might be a judgmental car. It's fine. What can you do? Keeps judging, makes so much noise, everything inside is jangling. Judgment, judgment, judgment... What can we do? Metal against metal, wire against wire!



5.

Beware of the cult of the present moment and mindfulness

(Mandu, 2018)



Questioner (Q): How can we, in daily life, go closer to the Truth? Is that through sitting, walking, working, meditation, through living mindfulness in the present moment? Isn't mindfulness taught by the Buddha himself?

Acharya Prashant (AP): Oh really? Which Buddha are you referring to? The Buddha of the West's construction, the Buddha of the neo-spiritualists and neo-advaitins, the now-ness movement, the mindfulness movement? Which Buddha are you referring to? Show me, where is Buddha talking of mindfulness? Show me!

It is a cult. It is an extremely foolish but dangerous cult, the cult of mindfulness. Please be very, very cautious of it.

In the name of mindfulness, at worst you can get caught in a universe projected by your own mind, and at best you will start concentrating on the things that your mind likes or dislikes.

No scripture ever talks of the present moment. Never, never! It is a fake spiritual philosophy emanating from industrial roots. It is driven by nothing but escapism and consumerism. It is both ineffective and impractical, and it is dishonest to boot.

If you are the one who has been living a debauched life, how will the burden of your past not haunt you? Because you are still that same person.

But in the name of 'present moment' and 'living in the now', you are taught to disown the past. In the name of disowning the past, you try to disown all the bills that you owe, all the bills that you need to settle, all the dirt that needs to be cleaned.

You can try to disown, but that won't happen. That's why I am saying it is ineffective and impractical, and because you don't want to settle your bills, so I am calling it dishonest.

The only way to disown your past is to not remain the same person anymore that you were in the past.

But that's not what mindfulness or present-momentists talk of. They will never talk of surrender or devotion. They will not say, "Give yourself up." They will just say, "Live in the present moment."

How can you live in the present moment? This very body is a carryover from the past. All that you are carrying in your pocket is coming from the past. Give it up! Why don't you? If you want to live just in the now, please empty the pocket!

But even the founding patriarch of the nowness movement would not empty his pockets. In fact, his pockets are bursting from the seams. So much of royalty he has earned from now-ness!

You cannot give up the past. There are only two ways: either settle all the bills that you owe, or die completely. No third way is possible. The third way is of dishonesty, the third way is of 'living in the now'.

When you say, "I want to live in the present moment," why do you want to discard the past? Were the past great for you, would you want to discard it? Why do people want to live in the now? Because the past haunts. And if the past haunts, surely there are bills to be settled. That's why it haunts.

The only honest way is: settle the bills or die. Because if you are dead, then nobody would come to you with the bills. But neither do you want an honest settlement of the bills, nor are you prepared for a spiritual-psychological death.

That spiritual-psychological death is called freedom from the ego. You won't be prepared for that. Instead, you just want to deny yourself the memories. It is selective amnesia—selective and, obviously, fraudulent amnesia, like someone who forgets only the dislikable things, the creditors.

"Oh, I am so forgetful—but I don't forget the ones I have to extract money from. I only forget the ones I have to pay money to!" That kind of forgetfulness is the now-ness movement. And there are so many roaming around, you know. "Just live in the now, man, and chill! Why do you have to worry about the future?"

You *must* worry about the future. Why must you not? Given what you are, you must worry about the future.

The saints have kept singing of death and how the buffalo man will take you away. Are they not referring to the future? Tell me. You must know

what the future of your bodily organism is. And why must you worry about the future? Because you do worry about the future. Since you do keep thinking of the future, so the saints tell you: in the future lies death.

But here are the now-ness people; it is the credit card industry. “Forget the future, just swipe it, man! And forget that you have to settle the bill.” Only the credit card companies will benefit. As I said, it is driven by industrial and financial concerns. They want you to consume, and a lot of consumption is happening in the name of now-ness.

“Enjoy the moment! Go with the flow!” What is that flow? Where is it coming from? Why should I go with it? Why don’t you just pause and ask, which flow are we talking of?

“Go with the flow!” The tsunamis are coming to take you away, and the great master is teaching you, “Go with the flow!”

And so much of it is happening in the name of Buddhism. A lot of these Southeast Asian Buddhist monks and so many of them are teaching only this thing: mindfulness, go with the flow, present moment. Ah! Shaven heads!

Kabir Sahib had some generous advice for these shaven heads. What was it? He said that if by shaving your hair you could attain liberation, then the sheep would have been liberated long back. Why don’t you rather shave off all the nonsense that is there in the mind, not over the head? *“Kesho kahan bigadiye jo munde sau baar, man ko kahe na mundte ja me bhare bikar.”*

Be very cautious of these fads. Sometimes they present you naked falsenesses, and sometimes they present you half-truths. And the half-truth is worse than falseness. The monk who sold his Ferrari—and bought a private jet. That’s what they will not tell. Beware of the private jet monks!

I have recounted that horrible incident not less than five, seven times, and it still haunts me. You know, I am not free of the past. It does haunt me!

I was in Pondicherry, and it was morning time. And there was this westerner lady, and she was walking on the grass, the lawn, and she was taking one step at a time. So, she will take one step, then pause, and then very slowly she will raise her leg and keep it on the grass, and then she will again raise her leg and keep it on the grass. And like this she was trying to walk.

I watched for five, ten minutes. Then, with very ignorant curiosity, I approached and said, “Ma’am, what are you trying to do?”

She said, “I am practicing mindfulness. I want to take each step mindfully!”

I said, “This will make you go mad! What all will you do mindfully?”

She said “No, all these things happen in a flow. We must break the flow! Mindfulness means you must be aware of every bit of the action, so you break it. All those things that happen in a flow must be stopped and broken down into their tiny bits.”

I felt like asking, “How about urination? Will it now happen drop by drop?” But that would have been against spiritual decency.

What is this, “Be mindful”? There are those who say, “When you are eating, take it in slowly, and then focus on each and every movement of the jaw.” To hell with you! Here is my *golgappa* and in it goes! They have never come to India. In Indore, they never went to Sarafa bazaar. They do not know the sheer pleasure of just devouring it in! Can you take in a *golgappa* like that, mindfully?

All that they are teaching is concentration. They are not saying, “Please see who is walking. Please see why is she walking at all.” That they will not teach. They will say, “When you are walking, focus on each step. Even if you are walking towards the graveyard, even if you are walking towards your own end, keep each step mindfully.”

The one basic spiritual question that there is, that they will never ask. Who? What? Why? That they will not ask. And it gratifies the ego greatly.

You know, I am sipping this (*raises a glass of water*)—mindfully! And, you know, I experience the water go down my throat and then reach the stomach. Why not after that? Why are you stopping?

Q: They are taking pleasure in it.

AP: It is all experiential. You want to prolong and deepen the experience.

Q: Mindfulness and being conscious are both the same thing?

AP: The same thing. And quite closely related to this is the practice of Tantric methods. A lot of that is also just about mindful sex. “Be very mindful!” They will not say, “Why the hell does this thing exist?” They will not say, “Who is the one eager to copulate?” They will not say, “What does it do to the one who is eager?” Those things are not to be asked. They will just say, “You know, when you are doing it, be mindful!”

And what does being mindful mean? Being more conscious.

Spirituality is the transcendence of consciousness. Spirituality is to see that all elements of consciousness are in the same dimension and are not to

be taken seriously.

Mindfulness makes you take everything seriously. Even a simple act like walking is now being taken very seriously. Spirituality gives you freedom to fly in abandon, fly without any mindfulness, zero mindfulness. “What is happening is just happening. I don’t need to be mindful.”

Mindfulness is such a curse, such a burden. Am I mindful as I speak? Not at all! In fact, my being is the biggest proof against mindfulness. I speak, as I do right now to you, with zero mindfulness. I do not know what I am speaking, or whether I am barking.

I have no mindfulness. My hands do not move on my command.

What is this thing about doing it rightly? I am not the doer!

What is this thing about walking carefully? I have no cares, I only have abandon!

I am not mindful about anything, and this is mysticism.

And the West is mighty scared of mysticism. Their spirituality is just timid psychology—psychology that is so very afraid it cannot step out of its sanitized enclosures.

I come from India and my spirituality is that of the Himalayan jungles. No enclosures there, no safety there, no promises there, no sanctuary there, no mindfulness there. Pure, fearless wandering, without bothering to inquire what is going on.

“*Mala phirun na jap karun mukh se kahun na Ram, sumiran mera hari kare mein paaun vishram.*” Where is mindfulness in this? Where is mindfulness? “Neither do I practice with the rosary, the beads, nor do I practice remembrance, *japa*. I do not even utter the name of Rama from my mouth. I don’t bother to remember anything! What mindfulness? I am not mindful of anything. The Lord takes care of me. I do not remember the Lord; the Lord remembers me. I just relax.” This is spirituality.

Spirituality is relaxation. Mindfulness is taxation, it burdens you.

Q: Breathing mindfully!

AP: Breathing mindfully! What else? Why limit yourself to only one bodily process, breathing mindfully?

I dare you, how about urinating mindfully?—especially when the bladder is about to burst! Try holding it. Hold it, then drop it; hold it, then drop it. And then you will realize what a pain this mindfulness thing is. It should happen drop by drop. Try!

Or ejaculating mindfully! You know, half a drop by half a drop. Try! I suspect the hidden motive is to pain the practitioner so much that he just drops out of himself. Then this mindfulness is a great practice! If you just want to trouble the practitioner, then this is great.

You know, bathing mindfully, drop by drop. One drop at a time, then another drop. All the women should practice this, especially the ones with long hair. One drop at a time you will get, and be mindful! Now one drop has come, one more drop has come... That will be the last bath you will take. Now you are liberated from all kinds of purification!

I repeat, in the greatest traditions of spirituality, the saints have always asked you to remember your past and also never forget the future. Kabir Sahib goes to the extent of reminding you how you were in the mother's womb. He said, "You remember? In the mother's womb, your head was pointing downwards, in the sense that you were a little humble; your feet were up and the head was down. And now that you are born, your head is so stiff!" What is he asking you to remember if not the past?

In fact, you talked of Buddha. What are the Jataka tales? What are the *Jatak Katha*? Tell me. What are they? They are the stories of the hundreds of past lives of the Buddha. He remembered not only his past years of this life, but also all the previous lives. Surely, he was not mindful. Surely, the now-ness movement would not have agreed with the Buddha. He not only remembered all the past lives, but also narrated them, got them chronicled, and now they are of tremendous use to everybody.

I am not advising that you must stick to the past, but I am telling you that you cannot escape away dishonestly from the past.

There are, I would repeat now, only two ways to unburden yourself of the past: settle your bills, close the loop, which are the same thing, or die. Die not in the physical sense but in the spiritual sense: die to the past.

But if you want to remain alive to the past and still act as if the past doesn't exist, then you are just being crudely dishonest. It won't work.



6.

How to meditate continuously for 24 hours?

(Rishikesh, 2020)



Questioner (Q): A couple of days ago, I asked you a question regarding thoughts at the time of meditation, and you completely destroyed me. I have been trying to assimilate what you had said.

So, the point you had mentioned is that meditation cannot be only a one or two hour practice a day. It has to be something in which, throughout the day, you are able to be in a state where you don't engage in actions that develop thoughts that bother you during meditation.

I have been listening to you and trying to understand this, but I am not able to get the full grasp of it. The mind keeps coming back saying, "How can you be in action during the day, trying to do things, trying to achieve things?"

And the purpose of meditation is that you probably want to sit for one hour a day just to be calm, trying to do some prayer, trying to do some listening to keep yourself down. The effect you can see: that after you do the prayer and meditation, you are able to feel calm. But during the day, unfortunately, the mind slips out: you get aggressive, you want to prove things, your identity steps in.

So, the question is, is there a way that you can be in a meditative practice throughout the day? Through the last two or three days with you, which have been very useful, I have understood that you need to engage in actions which do not create conflict in you; that is something which I am taking away from these sessions, but I am not able to get it clearly.

Acharya Prashant (AP): No, you don't need to do anything. This one special hour of meditation is something that you do. When it is something that you do, then it remains a function of the doer. So, the doer expresses himself as another doing called 'meditation'.

You are anyway doing a lot of things. See what is it that you are doing.

And if you see no peace in that, good for you. If you are saying that you have tried to observe your daily actions, thoughts, emotions, etc., and you have seen anger and conflict and distraction, and therefore you feel that meditating twenty-three hours a day is difficult, then your meditation is actually succeeding. And I am talking of the twenty-four-hour meditation. At least now you are able to see how your entire day actually is.

And our nature is such that if we really encounter noise and acknowledge noise as noise, we will no longer be able to support noise. If we encounter conflict and do not try to give it a made-up name or decorate it, instead if we just acknowledge it as conflict, then we will no longer be able to support it, and therefore we will not sustain it. That is meditation.

It's just that real meditation is a dirty thing. It is a dirty thing because it needs you to plunge directly into the dirt and filth of your daily life. Artificial meditation of the one-hour type is a very clean thing.

Having spent the entire day in the—pardon me the usage—gutter of common life, we come back to the one clean, holy place that we have artificially reserved for meditation, take a shower, use some incense, play some mystical music, and sit down to bathe in the divine. What nonsense!

Real meditation will be tricky, dirty, and quite hurtful. It involves seeing things for what they really are. It involves acknowledging your own face. Real meditation is about showing a mirror to yourself.

False meditation of the kind that is very popular is all about putting up the most artificial, the most made-up, and the holiest face possible. Look at people when they are meditating. Is that them? Seriously? Look at people when they are strutting around with their yoga mats, and sitting in this āsana (yogic posture) or that āsana. Is that them?

Returning from his yoga class, he seriously relishes a piece of chicken leg. In fact, the chicken feels even more delicious after the yoga class! Having meditated, he immediately sets off for his shop—and he is a champion black-marketer. And meditation helps him in staying calm and quiet while he is fleecing the entire world.

What kind of meditation is this? This is meditation just to sustain the ego, right?

Real meditation is dangerous. Therefore, real meditation is neither practiced nor taught. And obviously, it cannot sell.

Real meditation is a daylong, lifelong activity. It is a love affair. You cannot be a lover one hour a day, or can you be?

But you can be a customer of flesh one hour a day. That is something you can do just on weekends, or every night after 10 p.m. just before you go to bed. Your daily dose of flesh, right? Love is not something that you can have only at 10 p.m. at night. Tricky? (Chuckles) But 10 p.m. love is convenient. Meditation is not 10 p.m. love or 7 a.m. love.

What happens is that most of these famous, or fashionable, or popular spiritual practices just make the same old ego start feeling good about itself. The ego does not change; it just starts feeling good about itself. And that is very dangerous, because now all the possibility of change has been totally blocked.

You change only when you are dissatisfied with the way you are. But instead of bringing you to change, if you are given some technique that helps you be as you are and yet feel divine and blissful and whatnot, then who can save you?

Real spirituality is not about pretending that you are already the Ātman, that you are already the pure Self, the Truth. Real spirituality is about seeing that there is no way you are the Ātman, that you are the stinking ego lightyears away from the Ātman.

Real spirituality is not about pampering yourself with notions like, “You are already beautiful. You are great as you are. Aren’t you already the supreme Truth?” All this is just self-deception, right?

Look at the way you live. Look at the way you relate, consume, buy, eat. Are you already the supreme Truth? Exactly how? (Chuckles)

But we all require teachers of the kind who can come and certify to us that we are great and pure as we are. And such teachers will be greatly in circulation, immensely popular. So, some trick can be given to you, some technique can be given to you, some hour can be allotted—and bingo!

I will repeat, real meditation is a love affair, and you pay for it with your life. It is an extremely dirty business.

The mind will have to bathe in its own blood. The mind will be illuminated, but only in the fire of its own annihilation. A lot of light is produced. We keep seeking light, don’t we? A lot of light is produced when the ego self-immolates. That’s the only light that can really illuminate the ego.

Q: When I am questioning myself, my mind comes back with an answer that whatever you are doing now is getting questioned, that my whole

lifestyle is going to get questioned to such an extent that I will probably really need to rethink, because what you are saying absolutely makes sense.

All the current spiritual practices, when I am logically able to see, it is only amplifying the ego, saying that “Yes, you have one hour of the good, but then, why am I here?” So, I am back into that loop where I am introspecting my entire lifestyle, which will be very interesting.

AP: Dangerous. Interesting from a distance.

Q: Interesting from a distance. It is scary.

AP: Very dangerous when you actually come to it. Scary! (Laughs)

Q: Thank you. Nobody has given this kind of visibility.

AP: (Laughing) You are thanking me for bringing scare to you?

Q: I am thanking you because now I can stop fooling myself. After being on this path for some time, nobody has brought in this much of a different perspective, that this is something which is also there. So, if you are going to go in, there is going to be some good times, there is going to be some bad times, and eventually all of it should go away.

AP: It will really beat you down very badly. Let there be no consolations in this regard.

Leading a false life is quite convenient, and that is obvious from the fact that most people choose to lead false lives. Now you see the reason why. There is clearly a benefit associated with living falsely.

When you buck the trend, when you want to deviate from the common path, then there is a price to pay. And the bigger the deviation, the bigger is the price. It's just that after a while, if you have the patience to sustain yourself for that long, you discover that the price you were paying was actually the burden you were off-loading. So, it was not a price at all.

But when you begin to pay, it hurts. It will seriously hurt. Let there be no doubt about it.

Be prepared, and drop all the fantastic notions that spirituality brings bliss and this and that. First of all, the experience will be of great hurt. It would feel as if you are being torn apart. And you will have a great desire to return to your old ways, your old life. That's why patience will be difficult.

Even if there is bliss, it is a very courageous kind of bliss. It is the bliss that a warrior earns after sustaining a hundred cuts on the body. It is the bliss that you know of when you have fought wholeheartedly, and yet lost. That kind of a bliss, not the cheap kind of bliss which is very similar to physical pleasure and mental happiness.

Ask most people who talk of spiritual experiences or bliss or the divine touch. Are they talking of anything other than physical pleasure in some version of the same old kind of mental happiness? No.

Spiritual bliss has a totally different quality to itself. It is the bliss of the bankrupt man who has sold away everything he had for something very intangible, as intangible as love.

Probably, not all are cut out for it. Probably, this is a realm of only a few people. That's something very sad to acknowledge. The more you look at the world, the more you are forced to acknowledge this. Probably, not all are cut out for spirituality. Probably, not everyone has the intention to pay up.

Capability is earned along the way, so capability is not such a big problem. The problem is intention itself. People might just poke into the spiritual world, peep in for a while, window shop a little. But when it comes to permanently settling down in the land of Truth, there are very few takers.

We come to the land of Truth as tourists, with the return tickets already booked. We don't come to belong; we don't come to settle down, do we? That one hour of tourism, daily tourism, won't work. Just as this one week or one month of Rishikesh (the session is taking place in Rishikesh) foray won't work.

One doesn't go to the Truth on a visa.



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7.

Why don't you suggest meditation techniques?

(Rishikesh, 2018)



Questioner (Q): Acharya Ji, why don't you suggest meditation techniques?

Acharya Prashant (AP): When you were in the Ganges, were you querying about what water is? The fish asked the ocean, "So, when am I going to be schooled about water?" Since four days, what else have you done except meditation?

But you have images of meditation, right? Somebody with his head buried in the sand and legs trying to shoot down the sky—that is meditation!

You are meditative right now. If the fish feels that she does not know water, then she suffers a punishment. The punishment is that she comes out of the water to search for water. If you will not know that this is meditation, then you will break out of this and go into non-meditation.

To look into your life, to be honest about your experiences—what else is meditation? But this meditation is dangerous because it doesn't spare any corner of your existence. You have to be continuously watchful. You have to look at everything and everybody.

So, this meditation is a very inclusive meditation. This meditation is a very continuous meditation. You don't even want to call it meditation because it will consume your entire life; it will burn down the ego to ashes. So, you don't even want to call it meditation, right? You would rather call meditation that which is practiced in a corner of your being—in a corner and for a limited time.

You devote one corner of your house to meditation, and one hour of your day to meditation, and that you safely and confidently call as meditation—and that is not meditation at all! That is a dirty escape from the innate meditateness of life.

Q: But is not sitting silently and watching the breath good for relaxation?

AP: Why are you pushed to a point where you need to relax? Why are you living a life that tires you down so much that you need to relax? And by pursuing this method of relaxation, are you not protecting that needless life?

Physical exhaustion is understandable. If you work physically hard throughout the day, the body is tired. But when you talk of these methods of meditation and the relaxation associated with them, you are talking of mental relaxation, right?

Why is your life such that your mind is tired and bored and heavy?

Why are you pursuing such a life and such a profession?

Why is relaxation necessary at all?

It is man's natural state to be relaxed. The body can get tired. Why is the mind getting tired? Why are you living that kind of a life? If your body is tired and you want somebody to massage you, that is alright. But if you say, "Now my mind is tired," then I will question the life that you are living, not ask you to meditate, not give you a method of relaxation.

That method of relaxation is evil because it is perpetuating the evil life that you are leading.

Somebody asked me, "You keep speaking. Don't you get tired?" Something of that sort. And it is the same thing that I said. My throat indeed does get tired, but the mind is... I won't even call it fresh. It is just what it always is.

I sometimes speak for five, even ten hours a day; that has happened. Three meetings and then a couple of sessions; that too. Now, the body aches terribly. The throat, the back of the neck, they pain. But the mind? Is the mind tired? Never! The mind is alert and watchful and seated as always.

Running a massage center is an infinitely more honorable profession than running a meditation center. Massaging is real service, not meditation!

Q: So, how can you erase this strain on the mind and the need for meditation whilst living life with a normal 9:00 to 17:00 job?

AP: Yeah, of course, the kind of jobs that most people are involved in will simply wear them down. Are they 9:00 to 17:00 anymore? I thought since 2008 they are 9:00 to 20:00.

Q: It is just a phrase.

AP: Just a phrase, right? It occupies the entire 24 hour cycle. The phrase must be honest so that it doesn't mislead you. The phrase is not divine. Man made it, and man can then refine it and modify it. At least in India, it is not 9:00 to 17:00. Not even in the West, I suppose.

Don't ask for cosmetic treatments. Hit at the root itself.

You walk on thorns, and then you apply some ointment, some dressing to your feet only to enable you to walk the next day again on thorns. Slowly, you will get gangrene. The leg itself would be amputated.

Pain serves a very important purpose, please. And that is why I am totally against wisdomless treatments of pain.

In physical nature, why does pain exist? What purpose does pain serve? Please, tell me. Pain tells you that you have gone wrong somewhere. Pain tells you: do not repeat what you are doing.

When something pains, you cannot use it, right? That is how pain operates in the body. If the fingers are paining grossly, can you use them? Which means, stop using the fingers the way you have been using them.

But what do you do? You come up with cosmetic treatments, the so-called methods of meditation.

And now the finger is still internally unhealthy, but you are, through cleverness, through trickery, making it work. What will happen to the fingers? They will slowly just keep dying.

Pain does not come for no reason. Pain comes so that you know that you are not living, walking rightly. Acknowledge pain, and be more loving and sensitive towards yourself. You don't need to lead a life of suffering. You are not obliged to keep inviting pain.



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8.

Does meditation lead to a passive life?

(Rishikesh, 2017)



Questioner (Q): When we meditate regularly, our desires start diminishing; we are not as inclined to act as per our wants. But then, is that not equal to becoming passive in life? Can you please say something about that?

Acharya Prashant (AP): You see, had you not been told in advance that the so-called meditation will turn off your desires, are you sure you would experience a diminishing of desires?

I repeat, even before you entered the process of meditation, had you not been told what the fruits of meditation are, would you still have experienced those fruits?

If desires are really gone, then you know that that which you are calling as passivity is the greatest joy of relaxation. But desires are very much there. The so-called meditation is only used to put a veneer on them.

I assure you that the very same meditation would fail if you are *told* that it fails. You are told it succeeds, so it *appears* successful to you. But had it *really* been successful, I am asking you, would you call the fruit of meditation as passivity and be worried about it?

When one is really in love, does one treat the fruit of love as a worry? If you have really meditated, would you treat the fruit of meditation as a worry? When you are one with God, do you treat the gift of God as a worry?

The gift is a worry only when there is no gift. Meditation is still to happen.

What is meditation? Is meditation about sitting in a particular place, following a particular set of physical and mental disciplines, subjecting the body to behave in a certain way, reserving a certain time in your daily schedule for peace? Is this what meditation is?

Is meditation something that can be taught as an activity? Surely, if meditation is to be sold, then it has to be taught as an activity. Because if

meditation is not really an activity, then how will it become tangible? And if it is not tangible, why would you pay for it?

Meditation is the mind looking directly at that which it really wants. The mind wants peace. The mind wants to relax and go to sleep. That total sleep is also called *Samadhi* (dissolution, union).

When the mind is not acting as its own enemy, when the mind is going in the direction it anyway intends to go, that is meditation.

When you are fulfilling your deepest and ultimate desire, that is meditation.

When you are doing what you must do and not doing what you must not do, that is meditation.

Meditation is not something that you do. Meditation is something that you allow to happen to yourself.

Meditation is not something that purifies you. Meditation is something that dissolves you.

After purification, you hope to retain some kind of a purified self, and a purified self is a bigger pride than an impure self, is it not? We love to say, “I am a meditator, so my mind is more evolved and more stainless than yours.”

Meditation is that which leaves you with nothing to take credit of.

Meditation is not something that will help you fulfill your goals. Meditation is that in which your biggest goal has already been realized.

A Zen saying puts it very pithily. It says, “When you have reached the top of the mountain, keep climbing.”

To reach the top of the mountain is meditation. To keep climbing even after you have reached the top is meditation.

And that meditation cannot be confined to a particular hour of the day. That meditation cannot be a set of predefined activities. That meditation is life itself. That meditation is being committed to the top of the mountain twenty-four hours a day.

You are a very poor climber if you climb just one hour a day, and for twenty-three hours you squander your time—and worse still if for twenty-three hours you climb downwards.

Meditation is to keep climbing twenty-four hours and to not stop climbing even after you have reached there.

This real meditation is very, very dangerous because it leaves you with no time and no allowance for anything else. You must keep climbing, and

that is your permanent job. You can't do anything else.

The meditation that is usually sold and practiced is the meditation in which you can very conveniently make allowance for everything that you stand for. You say, "One hour of my day belongs to meditation, and bingo—twenty-three hours belong to me! Not only do these twenty-three hours belong to me, I can now use these twenty-three hours with the added confidence and pride that I am a meditator."

If meditation is really so dear to you, why do you meditate only for one hour? If meditation is really so precious, why do you meditate only for one hour? Why not twenty-four hours? What kind of love is this that reserves itself only to a very small fraction of the day? Don't you want to be with the Beloved continuously?

You don't want that when you have ten other things to be attracted to.

Real meditateness is your life breath. And because it is your life breath, it must remain unnoticed. If you can know when you are meditating, then you are not meditating at all. That is the one test. Just as, if you know when you are loving, then you are not loving at all. If you know when you are speaking the truth, then truth is alien to you.

Meditation is either continuous or never. It cannot be intermittent. To be continuously in service of the Deepest is meditation.



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9.

Do not meditate for peace, meditate in peace

(Rishikesh, 2016)



Questioner (Q): Is meditation required?

Acharya Prashant (AP): What is meditation?

Q: For example, concentrating on the breathing.

AP: Have we not already talked of concentration? To concentrate is to force the mind to a particular object, and the mind does not like being forced. So, is meditation about concentration? Then the mind will never agree with meditation. Or, is meditation something else?

What is meditation? The very action of a peaceful mind is called meditation. Whatever you do in peace is meditation. This is meditation. That is meditation. All is meditation.

Meditation does not bring peace. Meditation begins in peace. Peace is not the end of meditation; peace is the beginning of meditation.

You cannot meditate in order to be peaceful. When you are peaceful, all is meditation.

And what prevents you from being peaceful? The idea that you need to do something to get peace. So, the very effort to meditate is a barrier to meditateness.

Wherever there is a formal structure of meditation—an effort, a method, a technique—it is guaranteed that there can be no meditation there, not even by chance. Because now you have institutionalized, formalized, decreed that you are aiming towards peace.

One lives in peace. One doesn't aim towards peace. Your efforts don't further peace; peace furthers itself. Whatever you do in peace reinforces the peace. Whatever you do believing in the absence of peace only extends the apparent absence of peace.

Your friend is in your home, you believe he is not there. Since you believe he is not there, so you switch off all the lights, lock the house, and

go out looking for him. Now, what will happen? Will you ever find him? When you go out looking for that which is already in your home, you have guaranteed that you will continue searching.

So, never begin with a flawed assumption. Never.

That's what all the meditators are doing—locking up peace in the house, switching off all the lights, bolting from the outside, instructing the guard to shoot anyone who tries to go in or get out. And then they have gone all over the place looking for the friend. “Where is He? Where is He? God! God! We can't get you, God! God the unreachable, God the unthinkable, God the unknowable, God the unnamable!”

He is sitting in your home. Go, open the door!

Jesus said, “Truth knocks.” Here, God is knocking from the inside. Jesus was joking when he said that “Knock and the door shall be opened.” You don't have to knock; the Truth is knocking and that too from the inside. Open the bloody door!

But you are busy meditating. You have come to Rishikesh, your friend is there in your home thousands of miles away, and you are searching for him here. How will you get him here? How exactly?

That's the essence of all spirituality: Your Friend lives in your home. The Friend is always home, don't look elsewhere.

Not only so, chances are you will go back, open the door, find him in, and beat him up. “Who are you? Thief, intruder, burglar, how did you get in? Because I am sure nobody was in when I went away; I am confident of my search. And you can't be my friend because my friend is lost somewhere outside. So, the one who is inside surely has to be an enemy. Let me give him a good thrashing, maybe call up the priest to exorcise the ghost!”

Anybody who convinces you that Truth, peace, or God are far away cannot be your well-wisher. Is that not obvious? Anybody who convinces you that you require a how-to, a method, some trick to reach your Beloved cannot be a lover. Isn't that obvious?

If I love you, would I convince you that you are ugly? Why doesn't this strike you: that none of these institutions—corporations, society, media, religions—ever tell you that you are alright? Why do they always tell you to progress? Why do they always encourage you to become better? And if somebody is encouraging you to become better, is he really your well-wisher?

Even the family—if your family members are insisting that you must rise in life and progress, do they really know love? Have you ever wondered what is this thing called progress and betterment?

There in the cities they want to rise to higher levels of salary; here, you want to rise to the higher levels of consciousness. What is this whole thing called progress and upliftment and rising? What is this?

Somebody wants to excel in the corporate, somebody wants to excel in consciousness. Higher salary, higher spirituality. Don't you see that ultimately you want to become better, you want to rise higher? Who convinced you, first of all, that you must rise? Don't you see they are all one? They are all running a race—a race that is unworthy of being run.

A few years back I had joked and said that “The race was won, by the one, who did not run.”

This race you can win only by not running. If you move even an inch, you have lost the race. This race only takes you away from yourself. Don't run it, don't participate.



10.

Don't become a prisoner of meditation practices



Questioner (Q): I am paying attention to what I do and how I do. I have observed four states of mind.

The first state: thoughts keep arising and I get lost. Most of the time, these thoughts relate to fear and worries.

The second state: I make a conscious decision to think about something, I am aware of the decision, but then the stuff of stage one intervenes and carries me away again.

The third state: I sit silently doing *prāṇāyama* (breath control) and paying attention to the breath. Thoughts keep arising in the background. I try to keep my attention on the breath. I keep hearing sounds near me, but I still remain attentive.

The fourth state: I am working on something and completely absorbed in it without any thoughts and don't even realize anything happening around me. I am just completely absorbed in what I am doing.

Is it natural to observe this? Are these all the same or different? And by doing it, will I go closer to a better quality of attention or *dhyāna* (meditation), or is it another trick of the mind?

Acharya Prashant (AP): When you are mentioning these four states, you are probably assuming a progression. The first state is when thoughts arise and take you away; it is almost like getting kidnapped. And in the fourth state, you are talking of the disappearance of thoughts. In the fourth state, you say you are just completely absorbed in what you are doing.

You are assuming a progression. The progression is there and is equally not there.

When you are really, really attentive, you will just not know about yourself. In all the four states, you have described what is happening to *you*,

which means that your state is going to and getting registered in your memory.

Remember that memory registers only distractions. Memory cannot register the Truth. Memory cannot register that which is natural and normal.

As a crude example, see whether you are registering that the air pressure, the atmospheric pressure is normal right now. Anybody whose memory is registering this? But if the atmospheric pressure gets reduced and there is oxygen deficiency, then memory would quickly register it.

Memory registers only that which has an irregularity, that which has something deficient or diseased about it.

Why are you registering these four states? Surely none of these four states are states of fulfillment. The proof is that they are mere states. What is the definition of a state? That which comes and goes. Truth doesn't come and go. So, if you are describing a particular state as a state of Truth or Godliness or attentiveness, then you are mistaken.

Stop being a watchman. Attention is not about keeping an eye on yourself. Attention is about being an attendant to the Truth. Attention is about not getting identified with whatever you are phenomenally doing.

It is subtle, understand this. The man who is driving towards the snow-clad hilltop must keep looking at the road immediately ahead of him, and he must also know what the dashboard is saying. At the same time, he cannot belong to the milestones, to the crossings, to the road, to the scenery, to the dashboard, to the music in the car. He must keep belonging to the destination; he must keep belonging to the hilltop.

That's attention. Keep doing whatever you are doing, but keep belonging there. And when you belong there, then whatever you are doing gets aligned to That.

If you are driving to the hilltop, you cannot say that these mortal eyes will keep looking at the hilltop. Driving towards the hilltop, if you keep looking towards the hilltop, then you will surely get an accident. At the same time, you cannot forget the hilltop, you must remember the hilltop. That remembrance is attention.

The hilltop that I am talking of is a physical destination. Truth is not a physical destination, but remembrance is still needed. Now, it is a strange demand. We know how to remember physical things; memory is equipped

for that. But the saints have continuously told you: remember, remember, and remember; *sumiran, surati, sumiran, surati, sumiran, surati*.

How are you to remember something that is not physical, not material? You know that. That is attention. You must have that knack, you must have that love. And then you can remember even that which cannot be seen, not be touched, not be experienced—not even be remembered.

Remember That, and keep your eyes on the road. That's attention.

I attend to the Truth. I am a servant of the Truth. I am devoted to peace. And devoted to peace, now peace decides my actions. When I have taken somebody as my master, how can I make decisions on my own? Who will decide my day-to-day decisions? Who will decide for me?

Q: The destination.

AP: The destination will decide for me. The master will decide for me. I am cursed if I take a single personal decision.

And that's the mark of the inattentive mind, that's the mark of the arrogant mind that refuses to surrender: this mind keeps taking personal decisions. This mind has no need to seek permissions. This mind says, “I will decide where the car will go.”

If you will decide where the car will go, one thing is certain: the car is not going towards the destination. The nature of this destination is that the destination must become the driver; otherwise, you won't reach.

Must have happened with you. You asked somebody to help you cross the river. The fellow says, “The river can be crossed this way.” The instructions have been given. You try to enact those instructions; you fail. So, you go to him and you say, “How to cross the river?” He says, “Fine, I will demonstrate.” So, he walks ahead of you, in front of you, and shows you how to cross the river. Again, you fail. Now, the only way you can be helped is when you let him hold your hand, when you actually let him put you on his shoulders and cross the river.

The destination must become the driver. The destination must carry you to itself. If you do not allow the destination to carry you on its shoulders, you will never reach.

It is a mark of stupid arrogance to say, “I know the destination and I will reach.” The destination can keep beckoning you, but you will not reach till you surrender to it, till you say, “You come and drive the car. I will just relax in the rear seat.” That is attention. “My task is You. Now You take care of my tasks.”

Differentiate between task and tasks. We get so lost in tasks that we forget *the* task. Attention is to have just one task in life. “And my task is to serve, my task is to attend, my task is to wait upon You. I am a waiter; that's my task. And now that I am doing my task, I have forgotten all about my tasks.”

The one who forgets his tasks finds that his tasks have been taken care of.

Sudama goes to Krishna and forgets what he came for, but he remembers the task: the task is Krishna. And he comes back to find that the tasks have been taken care of. There are several clever people who think that by doing the tasks they will fulfill the task; who say, “We are doing all the duties that have been prescribed to us.” You might be doing all the tasks, but you are severely deficient in the one task. You will not go anywhere. Just by doing your daily work rightly, you will not reach anywhere. The fact is you cannot do the daily work rightly unless you are, first of all, devoted to the right one.

Your only task is to be devoted to That. If you are not devoted to That, how can your daily task be right? You may keep thinking it is right, but it would all be botched up. That's attention.

Another crude example. When a little baby arrives in the house, look at the condition of the mother: she is doing a thousand things, but her ears are constantly tuned to the baby. The baby just whimpers in one room, somewhere in the corner of the house, and the mother is in the kitchen, and there is stuff and noise in the kitchen, but the mother knows something has happened. Quickly, she rushes. That's attention.

That does not mean that she is constantly physically with the baby. She is doing what is required of her daily life, but her priority is very clear. I am not edifying or glorifying the mother, get the example. The baby is no substitute for the Truth. Just get the example.

Constantly be tuned to That, and let that tuning dictate your slightest movement. *Constantly* be tuned.

Are you tuned in? Yes.

Are you tuned in? Yes.

Sometimes I say, never log out. That's the only way. That's attention.

Attention is not about “I watched this thought, I saw that, I did this.” Why are you doing all this? In self-interest? Is it a game? What are you

preparing yourself for if you have no lover? The lover comes first, and *then* you deck yourself up, right? Who comes first?

Q: The lover.

AP: The lover. Who comes first? The one you must attend to. And then you do all these things, and then they are nice and beautiful.

With no lover in your life, you are saying, “There are four kinds of haircuts and five kinds of dresses.” What will you do with them? And you are talking of this and that. Where is the lover in all this? Where is the one you must attend to?

Don’t become a prisoner of practices. All the practice is there to remind you of the lover.

You are practicing all kinds of methods—and there are a hundred methods of meditation, a million methods floating in the market. This kind of yoga, that kind of stuff; all greatly garnished and swollen and big, complete with the machinery and the decoration. Just one little thing is missing: the Lover.

The house has been greatly decorated, the guests have been invited; all the marks! The lady has been preparing since two months, four lakhs paid to the parlor—or that might be an understatement.

(Laughter)

Only one little thing is missing: the bridegroom, the *dulha*. Nobody talks of that. Everything else has been talked of!

Prāṇayama—what will you do with *prāṇayama*? What will you do with breath? The breath will anyway go away one day. You keep regulating the breath; one day there will be no breath. Somebody is pumping in and pumping out the belly. One day this belly will go to the fires—and you may have had a great belly. Half in, half out, this way, that way...

Where is the Lover? Where is the bridegroom? Is He there in your life? That's attention.

And somebody is adept at reading scriptures. The entire library is finished off! The bride is very well-read. Where is the bridegroom? Very well-read bride! So what? And then the bride comes and says, “You know, I do all the things rightly, I am doing all my duties.” There is just one task that you forgot: that task is the central task of life. Without that task, whatever you do, cursed it is.

That's why people come to me talking of this technique and that technique, and then they say, “Can you tell us whether we have mastered

everything rightly? I am taking in air from here and then exhaling from here, and then there is *kumbhaka*, and then there is *rechaka*.” Not that I don't know of these things, but I wonder at the stupidity.

What will you do with all this when the Lover is missing? What will you do? And it's not as if these things are not useful; they are greatly useful. You get a good body, you also get a silent mind. But you can have a silently stupid mind as well. Why don't you realize that?

There are many whose mind has been silenced by the incessant practice of techniques. But that silent mind is still a bereaved mind, it is still a stupid mind. You are silently grieving. Don't you see people who grieve, albeit silently? So, the mind has been put to silence. It is an artificial silence.

Real silence comes when you have consummated with the Lover. After that, you go off to sleep. That is real silence. You have met Him, now there is no *viyoga* (separation), and that is silence. Without that, what kind of silence? It is the silence of the graveyard. If you have no Lover in life and still you have practiced or cultivated silence, it is the silence of the graveyard. And there are many walking silently—like corpses. A corpse is very silent.

And you can get a very good body and call yourself a yogi. What will you do with this body? Keep admiring yourself! Will you be able to take this body beyond death? The body is the vehicle, the body is the instrument. Shiva Sutras say, the body is the *havi* (oblation, sacrifice, offering), the body is the offering.

The body is not an end in itself. What will you do by polishing your body and building up your body? Having a healthy body is important, but not the end. There have been loveless, ruthless, violent butchers in the history of mankind who had greatly fit bodies. In fact, to be a ruthless butcher you need to have a fit body.

A fit body in itself does not mean anything. Techniques of meditation by themselves do not mean anything. It is a thing of the Heart. It cannot be cultivated. You can only be reminded, and that's what I am doing. I am asking you, where is the love?

Attend to the Lover. That's attention.



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11.

Which method of meditation is correct?



Questioner (Q): Acharya ji, I have a question on these four commonly quoted methods: *śama* (restraint), *dama* (taming, subduing), *daṇḍ* (chastising, punishment), and *bheda* (division, difference). None of these methods seem to work. What to do? How to understand these methods correctly?

Acharya Prashant (AP): There are an infinite variety of methods, and all methods are available to you. Intelligence naturally knows the methods to apply. It's just that conditioning prevents you from applying methods. You take some methods as right, wrong, moral, immoral, applicable, inapplicable; whereas the rightness of any method in the spiritual domain is decided only by its ability to deliver the goods.

If something takes you to the Truth, it cannot be evil. But because we have no affinity for the Truth, no longing for the Truth, so we start thinking too much about the method.

You have to go to meet your beloved, and you missed the flight, and now you have to travel in the general compartment of a train. Would you mind it too much? It depends, actually; it depends on your relationship with your beloved. If you are really hungry to meet, then it won't matter how you are traveling; the method, the vehicle, would be of very little importance. And if you are absolutely bonkers, totally crazy, you may even decide to travel on foot—or even crawl. It depends on the longing, doesn't it?

The love itself suggests the method; from no other place can the method arise. Love will suggest you the method, love will show the way. If you are not able to find a way, it just means you don't love enough.

Śama is alright, *dama* is alright, *daṇḍ* is also alright, and so is *bheda*. And there is a world beyond these four methods. All these are alright, and

none of these are sufficient. Try everything, because you love—or probably you do not. You have to answer.

Don't be held back by notions. That which is worth attaining must be attained at any cost. No cost is big enough, no method is vile enough; no difficulty is too big, no sacrifice is too great; no tactic is too mean. If need be, deploy mean tactics and sacrifice your respectability. It is a form of sacrifice. It is a great sacrifice. One wants to remain respectable in his own eyes. Drop your respectability, sacrifice it. Be called a sinner. It is a great sacrifice.

A teacher went to a town where people were just too fond of entertainment, so he became a clown. That's the kind of method you need; that's the kind of sacrifice you need. The great teacher, flying high in his skies of venerability, has come down and become a clown. That's what love can do to you. That's what love *must* do to you. Otherwise, how will you live?

Sometimes the teacher, the lover has to act like a clown, because that is what you want; you won't settle for anything less. "He must tell me jokes, he must appease me." Fine! And sometimes the teacher has to employ *daṇḍ* also. You know what *daṇḍ* means? *Daṇḍa* (staff, stick, rod). From '*daṇḍ*' has come the word '*daṇḍa*'. Sometimes the *daṇḍa* has to be operated.

And sometimes you have to be bribed, *dama*, because you are so vulnerable to bribes. So, bribery is a good method. You are not prepared to come to the camp, so Anshu says, "Fine, your contribution can be reduced a little." What do you think is being done? You are being bribed to come to meditation. You are so used to bribery, you know? You never want to pay the full price. So, that's *dama*.

And what is *bheda*? See where the cracks are and use them. See which routes you can use to smuggle yourself into the mind of the student or the beloved. The example is happening: he (*referring to the questioner*) wants to read my secret book of tricks! It is a book that is rewritten every moment.

As I said, love shows you the way. Without love there can be no intelligence. The loving mind knows what to do, knows the way, knows the trick, knows the next tactic. 'Tactic' is a mean word, but in the company of love, tactics become lovely. Sweet tactics, sweet deceptions of love.

So, what prevents you? Go and employ all the tactics. Just make sure that the one employing and deploying is a lover, that's all.

Q: Osho's method of meditation was to take you to a peak through dancing, shouting, crying, laughing, etc. He called it a *recana kriya*. Was that method wrong? People are still following that method. He said that unless the things in the subconscious are not released, one cannot move ahead.

AP: We talked about it. We said all the dualistic methods have their utilities, and they are also limited. Useful, but limited. They can act as initiators, but they cannot take you to the end.

Osho gave you wonderful methods through which you can get a glimpse. Now, what you do with that glimpse depends on you. Osho sent you that invitation card along with sweets. He said, "Taste the sweets so that you are tempted further to come to the party." But what you do with the sweets and how you decide now depends on you, not on Osho.

He did his best. Not only did he organize the party, he sent you an invitation. Not only did he send you an invitation, he also sent you something that you can taste. But if you are still so thick-skinned that you say, "I will not leave my place, I will not join the party, and yes, I was quite hungry, but your sweets have satiated my hunger," then what can Osho do? What could he do when his commune was destroyed?

The great consciousness is within, but outside there are all the limitations related to the human form, the human body, the human birth. Everybody is helpless beyond a point. Osho could not reach the age of sixty. He should have lived long, but what to do with the human birth? One is helpless. Certain things happen. They just happen; one can't have control over them.

Similarly, Osho has very little control over your decisions. He is giving you methods to introduce you. Now you take the control, now you make the decision. Now you must announce that you have loved the sweets.

Osho himself said a thousand times, "Use the boat to cross the river, do not make a house on the boat." It is extremely foolish to forget that you have to reach the other side, that life is on the other side of the river. The river has to be crossed. One cannot get attached to the river itself.

And the boat is useful, but one cannot get attached to the boat. But sometimes you start taking so much pleasure in boating, in rowing... You know there is great pleasure in boating, go to Nainital and see. There everybody is just boating. In fact, people pay to boat!

So, that's what happens with the meditation practitioners also. They start taking pleasure in the rowing and the boating. Nice, nice! They forget

that the real thing is to quickly cross and leave the boat. You start boating for pleasure, you start wandering in the lake.

And the lake is still a very silent thing, a very still phenomenon. The river is turbulent, and the river is deep, dangerous. If you spend too much time in the river trying to enjoy yourself, you will not even realize when a sudden release of water or a whirlpool can mean your end.

Don't spend too much time on the boat. Quickly cross over and leave the boat. Osho gave you a boat; he didn't tell you to turn the boat into a plot. You are busy constructing palaces on the boat, and the poor boat is about to sink.

Be grateful for what Osho gave you, but remember that enlightenment cannot be given to anybody. That comes to you of your own accord, of your own decision. He can give you a method, but only you can give yourself liberation. Osho can at most give you a method, but only you can give yourself liberation. If you don't decide to give yourself liberation, what can Osho do? What can any teacher do?

No teacher can liberate you despite your wish. First of all, you must have a burning vision. Kabir puts it so beautifully. He says the first donor is the *śiṣya* (student).

“Pehele dātā śiṣya bhaya śīśa dina utaar—”

“Pehele dātā śiṣya bhaya.” Your role is more important.

”—pache dātā guru bhaya kinhi kripa apampar.”

You keep asking, what is the guru doing? Is this method right or wrong? But the guru is dependent on *you*. Unless you are prepared to sacrifice your head, what can the guru do?

“Pehele dātā śiṣya bhaya śīśa dina utaar; pache dātā guru bhaya kinhi kripa apampar.”

The first decision is made by the student, the central decision is made by the student. And only when the guru sees that the student is extremely keen, totally prepared to pay the price, then he can offer help.

In the spiritual journey, you see, the guru can hold your hand and take you only till a point. After that, the guru has to take your leave. After that, you have to continue solo. After that, you have to take the last step all by yourself. The guru can't help.



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12.

The pitfalls in the practice of mindfulness

(Dharamshala, 2019)



You are holding a rabbit in your hands. What else is there except sensory perception? Why must there be anything beyond sensory perception? Just look at the creature, look into his eyes. Let the perception be total, and you will realize what is beyond perception. But that comes as grace.

~ Acharya Prashant

Questioner (Q): I am not able to see the difference between this example and the philosophy of being mindful towards one's activities like eating, walking, etc. In one of your talks, you have discouraged the practice of mindfulness and mentioned that observation means: am I with the Beloved or not? It is observation of the inside. Please help me understand this better.

Acharya Prashant (AP): I have said, repeatedly, that you cannot be purposelessly mindful. Consciousness is anyway very, very burdened. Man's mind is a storehouse of all kinds of stuff. Man's mind is already full. You do not want to load it with more sensory objects.

So, when you do look at something, when you do admit something into your mind space, there must be a strong and valid reason. In other sense, mindfulness has to be very, very purposeful. Nobody should be allowed to gain entry into your mind unless the entry serves a clear purpose.

That's why I talked of the rabbit here; I didn't talk of anything in general. So, I said, look into the eyes of the rabbit. Now there is a purpose there, there is a gain there. I am not talking of admitting just anything into your consciousness. I am talking of admitting that which will give you insight. Insight about what? Insight about your own situation.

When you look at the rabbit, you will know who you are. The eyes of the rabbit, specifically, will tell you about your own longing. When you will

look at that animal, you will see something that will tell you who you are, and will not allow you, as a bonus, to kill and consume the rabbit.

So, if there is something that really benefits you with insight, then be mindful of it, then allow it entry into your consciousness. Otherwise, just being conscious of every little, trivial thing and object that is happening in you, around you, will leave you nowhere. There you actually have to be dismissive, regardless, oblivious—contemptuously oblivious.

Purposeful. Purposeful. You must know *why* you are looking at something. And the question then is, if you have looked at those videos carefully, “Am I with the Beloved or not?” That is the only question that must constantly occupy your mind space.

So, do be mindful of stuff that helps bring back this question to you, and be totally dismissive of other stuff. Just randomly and purposelessly counting the number of steps that you take from the kitchen to the washroom is no good. It is a random and dead practice. It will further burden and dull down your mind.

And when the mind becomes dull, then there is a temporary relief from suffering: active and searing pain turns into a dull ache, and many people prefer that. But the pain has not really gone anywhere; it has just become subsided, hidden, more palatable.

You are troubled by something, as most people most of the times are. You can occupy yourself with any random activity as a solution, and you will see that when you occupy yourself, then your troubles fade away for a moment. But is that a solution?

You have to ask the important and central question: Given who I am—and who are you? The longing consciousness. Given who I am, why am I doing anything, including observation? That’s the thing to be asked. Given who I am—I am somebody who is in need of healing—given who I am, why am I counting my steps? Why am I watching and counting my breath?

Nothing can be just a mindless practice. Otherwise, it becomes the absurdity of mindless mindfulness. So, when you say that mindfulness is good, I will say fine, but be mindfully mindful. Don’t be randomly mindful, because there is just too much filth that can fill up your mind. Why must you allow it?

The art of living is to not know a lot. There must be really a lot that you must not know at all. And when I say ‘know’, I mean knowing in a way that

affects you. And we do get related to the knowledge we have, don't we? And then the knowledge becomes burden.

Before you count something, ask yourself, why are you counting it? *Why* are you counting it? If the man who is counting currency notes all the time does not ask himself, "Why am I counting it?" then he is condemning himself to deep suffering. And if you do not know why you are counting, then there is not much difference between counting currency notes and counting the number of steps that you take as you walk from point A to B.

We are quick to point out the fault with the man who is busy counting notes all day, but we do not see that the man who is counting his steps all day is guilty of the same fault. Saints have constantly pointed at this trap. They have said, "Be cautious!" There are people who use the rosary, its beads, as a method of meditation. There are people who keep counting the number of times they have recited a particular mantra.

And if you will go to Kabir Sahib, Nanak Sahib, or other wise men, they will all tell you: "What is the point in counting till 108? What is the point in counting the number of times the rosary has gone through your fingers? Do you even know what is going on? It is just a dead practice, and it is further turning your mind dead."

What is meant by knowing why you are doing it? Knowing why you are doing something is to answer the question: Given that I am a longing consciousness, is this activity taking me there? If it is taking me there, I will count not till 108 but till 108000, no problems! If it is not taking me there, why am I doing this silly thing?



13.

Your meditation will not take you to the Truth

(Rishikesh, 2016)



Questioner (Q): The conventional theory around meditation is that it conditions the psychic apparatus so that you can more readily receive the *Ātman*. So, it is not without value. Are we so deluded that...

Acharya Prashant (AP): We are saying that falseness will be used to counter falseness. We are saying we have the sensibility and the intelligence to devise methods that will take us to the immense.

Q: But don't we need a method?

AP: Every method is a kind of rebellion against godliness. We are saying, "I will come to You using a method I devised." How is it possible to devise your own personal road to That?

Q: So, we have to call off the search?

AP: And you have to let Him call you. Only He can call you to Himself. Your own roads will not take you there.

Q: That's grace.

AP: That's grace; not a method but grace. And grace can't be methodical. Grace can't be cultivated, organized, taught, or learned.

Q: Sometimes we suffer enough to realize we can't control it, so we let go into grace.

AP: You have to let everything happen. Doing nothing, one lets everything happen.

Q: This seems so easy and difficult at the same time.

AP: Yes, yes. Difficult to our sense of control, "I want to control the happening." Easy if you just want to relax.

Q: So, we should stop resisting and have total acceptance.

AP: No, not acceptance, just non-resistance. Acceptance includes the right to reject. One surrenders the right to reject, and that is not acceptance. What

does one accept? One accepts only that which one feels like accepting. If you call it as acceptance, it can never be unconditional.

Q: Yes, it requires a judgment. You make the decision to accept.

AP: And you are saying, “I am accepting.” The difference is that in surrender, you are saying, “The ‘I am’ is being surrendered.”

In acceptance, the ‘I am’ accepts. In surrender, the ‘I am’ itself is surrendered.

Q: So, we should just have fun!

(Laughter)

AP: To many people it sounds so bad, that life is not a burden and you can just have fun. This is the greatest nightmare for the majority of people. “Fun? The great sin!”

Q: I had a lot of fun in the session last night, but the session this afternoon wasn’t a lot of fun. I would prefer to be back in yesterday’s session.

AP: Fun can never be as per one’s expectations. The fun that I am talking of is joy. Pleasure is as per one’s expectations. Last night you had a particular experience. Now it is inevitable that the mind will want to repeat that experience. And if the experience the next day is not similar to the previous nights, then it will not call it as pleasurable.

Q: You mentioned today that you too have expectations on how you would like the session to go.

AP: I don’t mind when my expectations are denied.

Q: What is your expectation? What were you expecting?

AP: Lots of expectations, like everybody else. For example, I do not expect you to not understand, I do not expect you to come late or leave early. Lots of expectations. But when they are denied or broken, it is alright.

Q: No attachment is there?

AP: Ah, it happens with everybody! We are not here to have our expectations fulfilled. Everybody will get that slap on the back, so I too get that. Now, what is so serious about it? Keep taking it!

Q: But there are so many issues in life, and some methods of meditation take you to a certain state that helps you to let go of your issues and feel relaxed and all such things. Isn’t that very beautiful?

AP: I just want to ask something. If that state is really, really what you wanted, then why do you opt to come out of it? If you really love Rishikesh, why do you go back? Why?

Q: Visa issues!

(Laughter)

AP: Ha! That's the thing with all organized trips, including the organized meditation trip every morning: you will have to go back. Spirituality is about loving it so much that you can never leave it. You can give up your nationality, your property, your body, everything, and yet not give up on it. That is love.

That's why organized methods are just a consolation. You can have that consolation if you are alright with it. There are some who are not alright with it; they want the real thing.

Q: It seems to me that meditation is more like taking a break, a holiday, and moving into a space away from most of the madness, and finding a calmness, a glimpse that can make you realize that there is more to what is happening than your usual...

AP: I want to say it is not even that, it is not even a glimpse. See, remaining an employee, a paid employee of that firm, even the holiday that you are taking you are taking *as* an employee. So, you cannot let go of that identity. When you very well know that your meditation time will stop and the clock is ticking, how can you ever go deep into *Samādhi*?

Q: Because you can let it go.

AP: How can you let it go when you know you have to come back?

Q: But you can let go of the meditation. So, you get that glimpse, you go into a certain depth...

AP: You won't even get that glimpse! Do you know what is the difference between vacationing as a free man and vacationing as someone who is drawn to return on a particular date? Do you understand the difference?

You can *never* go deep into relaxation when you know that you have a return ticket waiting for you.

That is why meditateness must be 24 hours, seven days of the week. When you are eating, walking, sleeping, talking, sitting here, I am meditating. This is meditation. Dancing, you are meditating. Simply walking down the street, you are meditating. You are *meditative*.

Q: So, does that mean that life itself should become meditation?

AP: Yes.

Q: I have seen a lot of people who are very into the ego, very occupied with their work, business, etc., and they use a process of meditation to calm their mind, because you cannot even concentrate well if your mind is not calm.

So, they go through a period of meditation, and then they drop the meditation once they are calm and go about their work. These kind of people would find it very hard to understand where you are coming from. They are satisfied with that small window of relief.

AP: See, it is not without reason that the sage is cautioning that *suṣupti* (deep sleep) is a trap of *Maya*. Similarly, I am cautioning that these meditation excursions are a trap of *Maya*. They are just parallels. When you get relief in this much, why would you want the immense?

Q: So, because it relieves your suffering, it means you can then carry on with your suffering rather than having the suffering build up.

AP: You have a tumor, and it is turning cancerous and it hurts, and some doctor provides you something which tranquilizes. Now, it *appears* to be good because you don't feel the pain. But what is really happening? You are continuing with the tumor now. That tranquilizer is enabling you to continue with your life. You may not perceive the suffering now, but the suffering is now internalized. That is what these meditation methods do.

Do you want tranquilizers, or do you want health?

Q: But you do get a sense of peace during the process and it is so nice.

AP: I am not denying or disputing that. All I am saying is: please continue with it, don't let it be confined to 30 minutes. I am saying, if you really like it as much as you are expressing, then why leave it in 30 minutes? Why not extend it to 24 hours?

Now, you have a problem; you must confront that problem. The problem is: if 24 hours you have that state, then your world will come to an end. Do you see that in experiencing that for 30 minutes you are preserving your world?

When people tell me that they experience this peace or that relief in meditation, I say, "Great. Now, if you really did experience that peace, why did you let it slip away? Hold on to it. Live your life as per that peace."

Q: I see that the longer I meditate, the more I get the carryover effect into the rest of the day.

AP: And won't you want that carryover effect to be as strong as the meditation itself?

Q: Yeah.

AP: So, that is what is meant by meditating 24 hours. Why only be satisfied with the remains, the residues, the carryovers? Have the full blast

continuously! The spiritual mind is really ambitious in that sense. It is not satisfied with dregs, with remains.

Q: We are conditioned to believe that we must do something to achieve.

AP: And hence our meditation is not deep enough. When you are still conditioned, where is the question of deep meditation?

I am not denying that at all: that which we call as methods of meditation were intended just to open the doors. But what to say if the doors are open, you enter, you touch the furniture, and then you run back? You are intended to stay there; not go there, write your name and come back.

Q: Sign the visitor's book!

AP: And sign the visitor's book, and then rush back to maintain your life and car and wife and family and society.

Stay there.

Q: Can we stay there and maintain a life?

AP: If you stay there you get a different wife!

(Laughter)

Q: But what if you genuinely like your life? Can't you just live in surrender and just flow?

(Silence)

AP: At this point where we have now reached, one can only pray. This is the point where we see the helplessness of being human. You know you can't proceed any further on your own, so you just have to stand still and drop your head. And that is prayer. Now your methods or your arguments or this session will not help anymore. Now only prayer can help.

Q: Is this how we generate grace? We have to ask for it?

AP: We open ourselves. It is already there, not generated.



14.

Does meditation help in liberation?

(Rishikesh, 2019)



Questioner (Q): What role does meditation have in increasing our chances of liberation?

Acharya Prashant (AP): If meditation is freedom from bondage, if that's what your meditation honestly is, then obviously meditation will help in liberation. But if meditation is just another thing, then what does it have to do with liberation? We very well know that if you want to be liberated, then you have to honestly admit and challenge your bondages.

So, that's what you must ask yourself. Is your meditation really challenging the real bondages of your life? Or is meditation just a small thing in a small part of your life, very distant from, very removed from the part of your life where strong bondages actually exist?

Mostly the kind of meditation that we practice is ornamental; it really does not address the core problem. It is like a tribute paid to liberation—a ceremonial thing, not actual. Man has a great capacity to co-opt even freedom into his slavery.

A lot of times what we call as spiritual practice exists just so that we don't have to address the real problem. Addressing the real problem requires guts and faith. And it is not as if we are so naive that we do not know where and what the real issue is, we know that, but we fail to summon the courage and the faith to take the bull by its horns. We would rather meditate.

When the enemy is knocking on the door, meditation lies in fighting, not in receding to a corner of the room, closing your eyes, and chanting some profound mantra.

Remember that meditation is for liberation; meditation is not an end in itself. Meditation that does not address and challenge the real bondages in your life is no meditation at all.

And that's also why meditation has to be a constant and unending thing, it cannot be a one-hour thing in the morning. Because one is being

challenged 24 hours, therefore meditation, the right response to challenges, too has to be continuous, 24 hours.

Meditation is meant to rid man of his slavery. But an hour of meditation every day becomes an excuse holy enough to allow you to continue in your slavery. One is able to justifiably say, “Am I not meditating? So, that box in my life is ticked. Now, having meditated, I can continue with business as usual.”

Meditation, then, allows a bit of temporary peace and a lot of moral relief. One says that “Life might otherwise be full of disquiet, violence, and dishonesty. But see, don’t I devote an hour every day to meditation? Am I not devoted to the Truth? That one hour is the proof that I love the Truth, that I am a peace-seeker.”

But by devoting one hour to Truth and peace, one has actually reserved the remaining 23 hours for something else. Obviously, if one hour belongs to Truth, that’s what it has been earmarked for. “6 to 7 a.m. in the morning I will be peaceful.” Then what are the remaining 23 hours for? And if peace is indeed so lovely, then how can the process of peace stop at 7 a.m.?

We co-opt even the highest and make it serve the lowly.

Q: Sometimes I feel the need for that one hour of withdrawal because the body and the mind feel tired. I just need a break.

AP: What are you withdrawing from in the first place? And if there is a need to withdraw from something, should there be a recurrent need to withdraw from the same thing? Please appreciate the question.

You find a man running crazy. You ask him, “What are you doing?” and he says, “A bull is chasing me!” So, he is running away from the bull. Two hours later you spot him again, and huffing and puffing he is still running madly. And you ask him, “What are you doing?” He says, “I am being chased by a bull!”

Now, bulls usually don’t have such fondness for any special person, especially of the male breed and that too another species. How is it that the same bull is chasing you hour after hour? Why is there a recurrent need to run away from something?

I am speaking in the context of withdrawal. I can understand if once you have to withdraw from something. But if something is worth withdrawing from, then why is that thing again and again present in your life? Why are you calling it as ‘normal life’ in your own words? Why are

you maintaining that ‘normal life’ if it is worth withdrawing from? That is dishonesty.

On one hand, you support that so-called normal life; you work hard to maintain and support that normal life, don’t you? If somebody asks you, “What do you work for?” you will say, “I work to support my normal life.” And then every morning you want to withdraw from that normal life for one hour. What kind of self-deception is this?

If this normal life is so ugly that there is a need for withdrawal, why don’t you let it come to an end? Is there not another life possible? Is that not what real liberation is? But most meditation is nothing but a continuation of bondages.

Q: In Patanjali’s eight limbs of yoga, one of them is withdrawal.

AP: Withdrawal is wonderful. But recurring withdrawal? If the bull chases you once, you do run away. But how is it that you are always found with a bull behind you?

(Laughter)

Withdrawal is alright. But how many times do you want to withdraw? Patanjali never knew that withdrawal would become a way of life. We are so adept at co-opting even the highest words for our own little purposes.

Real meditation is the courage to let life change. If you keep meditating without allowing life to change, this meditation is merely self-deception.

And when I say life must change, I am not talking of something imaginary; I am talking of things very, very tangible. I am talking of your relationships, your job, your house, your surroundings, your attitudes, your ideology. That’s what life is, no? That’s what the whole content of consciousness is.

If these things are not changing, if your dealings with your customers are not changing, if your relationship with your kids and your neighbors are not changing, if your dietary habits are not changing, if the way you spend money is not changing, if the way you look at the universe and the environment and the monkeys and the animals and the fish, if all that is not changing, of what point is meditation?

Q: Is awakening a one-time thing, or is it a gradual process?

AP: No, it is a continuous thing. You can never get rid of awakening. You can never be done with it. “Done, dusted, and sealed, awakened for life!” No.

Q: You have been talking about freedom and liberation. What exactly do you mean by that? Liberation from what?

AP: Bondages. If there are no bondages, then freedom is just a word. Freedom is meaningful only to those who, first of all, experience and admit bondages. Spirituality begins from there. All this is nothing but a rebellion against handcuffs.

Q: Acharya Ji, since our conversation yesterday, I have a few questions bothering me.

Once I was walking in a park, and in that one moment I found the grass to be very beautiful. And once I was out of it, I felt like there was no pre-assumption about that grass and it appeared so beautiful in its own way. It was a moment of how I connected to the grass.

So, I have this problem in understanding what is the difference between emotion and connecting, and how can I connect without the emotion? Because even when I say the grass is beautiful, there is an emotion attached to it.

AP: This 'I' that wants to connect, had it been one solitary, constant thing, then there could have been one uniform answer to this question. But this 'I' is itself very fickle. The one who is looking at the grass right now would not be the one who is looking at the grass an hour later.

Therefore, 'I' really does not connect to anything. 'I', being a constant hollowness, merely uses and projects itself on everything.

It is your mood that decides the greenness of the grass; it is your mood that decides the lustre of the grass. On another day, in the middle of another emotion, you might find the grass totally unattractive.

How, then, to really connect? Real connection is not possible with emotions or 'I'-ness. Real connection is when you are alright within yourself, when you do not have the need to use anything outside for the sake of your fulfillment. Then there is a relationship. This relationship is now friendly; it is not opportunistic or exploitative. Otherwise, we utilize even the poor grass for our own inner compulsions.

To really connect, do not be. When there is nobody inside with a need to connect, then real connection happens. As long as somebody inside is craving for connection, there would be a connection but the connection would be shallow, transient, and opportunistic.



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15.

The real meaning of meditation

(Advait Bodhsthal, 2015)



niḥsaṅgo niṣkriyo'si tvam svaprakāśo nirañjanaḥ
ayameva hi te bandhaḥ samādhimanutiṣṭhasi

You are now and forever free, luminous, transparent, still. The practice of meditation keeps one in bondage.

~ Ashtavakra Gita, Chapter 1, Verse 15



Questioner (Q): What is meditation? Why does the practice of meditation keep one in bondage?

Acharya Prashant (AP): Meditativeness is simply our inner nature. To meditate is different from any kind of mental exertion or mental activity. To meditate is to be at a point where parallelly two non-events are happening. First, there is no need for mental activity. Because there is no need for any activity, so I am calling it a non-event. There is no need to think or solve problems or resist challenges or plan; no need is felt. Secondly, parallelly, even though there is no need to gather knowledge, yet all is known.

Most of the knowledge that we have comes to us because the insecure one within us needs to have information from the world. That is the reason why we seek knowledge. There is a feeling of incompleteness and the possibility of some loss if that knowledge is not there. “Something would be reduced, something would be diminished within me if I do not have this knowledge.” That is the reason why we chase and store knowledge.

In meditateness, there is knowing without the need to know. Obviously, this knowing is not about people, things, ideas, concepts, or places, which themselves are products of insecurity. In the great security of meditateness, there is a great realization. Of what? Surely not of that which itself is a product of insecurity.

You come to simply know a great deal in meditation. But what do you come to know? Do you come to know about the politics of the country, about the economic situation, of what is happening in the neighbor's house, of all the things that man's mind has erected? No, none of that, because whatever man's mind has erected, it has done so as a response to the various challenges, to the various threats to its body and ego. That is what we have usually called advancement. That is not what you come to know of in meditation.

Remember, in meditation, firstly, there is no need to know. Secondly, all is known without the need to know it. Whenever there will be a need to know, all that you will know will be trash, inessential. Whatever knowledge will come to you out of your own will, your own desire and pursuit, will be worthless. Because who is chasing this?

Think of that entity that is chasing this. What can that entity chase? The entity that is chasing this is itself a product of a feeling of inferiority, which it seeks to treat through accumulation of knowledge. Surely, such an entity is not going to be able to treat itself by accumulation of knowledge because accumulation of knowledge will only prove that the assumption was correct.

One thinks himself to be sick and goes to buy medicine. If the medicine is given to him, if he is able to get medicine of *his* choice, that is not going to rid him of the assumption that he is sick. In fact, if a sick one comes to you and you tell him to take a few medicine, you have cemented the thought within him that he is indeed sick. That is not what happens in meditation. You have no need to know; you are not sick. You are not sick.

It is very pertinent that we notice how much of our need to know simply arises from the trivia, from the base rottenness accumulated inside us. We are always on a lookout to gather information. The senses are automatic accumulators of information, and the mind too is always on a hunt to know this and to know that. In fact, what we call human progress, to a great extent, is the availability of quick and easy information. Whatever you want to know is available to be known.

At the same time, it becomes very important to know from where the urge for that knowledge is coming and what the scope, the domain of that knowledge is. What will that knowledge be all about? Because the urge comes from thought, hence all the knowledge that can be gathered in the so-called normal thinking process will only be about the product of thought.

You can have lots of knowledge about what material is like, what the universe is like. Today, you can go to the internet and come to know where in a particular lane in Mexico a particular restaurant is located. All of these things can be very easily and very precisely known. But these things, even if they tell us a lot about the world, will never carry us to the underlying mystery of the world. That is not what normal accumulation of knowledge through senses and through the analytical process of mind can give us. We will know the material, but never the subtle origin of the material.

The very faculty that is asking for knowing is itself a material faculty. Neither does it have any desire to know the subtle nor does it have the capacity to realize the subtle. So, all that we will be filled with is gross, gross, and more grossness. What is gross is not beautiful and what is gross is devoid of its subtle root, its subtle origin. So, it is not really true—neither beautiful nor true.

That is what our usual mental processes give us: information, knowledge, and conclusions that are just material and gross—and they leave us craving for more. No knowledge is ever sufficient; you want more knowledge.

So, there is grossness and there is craving for more of this grossness; no coming to a stop, no stillness, and hence no peace. But surely, these being the essentials of living without which the mind is going to go mad, these too must be found.

Beauty, Truth, stillness, peace—there has to be something that validates them, that confirms their presence with such surety that you do not need to seek anymore knowledge or certification. A final stamp of their ‘is’-ness must be there, that they do exist.

Knowledge will never convince you that peace exists. Accumulate as much knowledge as you can about peace; that will not give you peace. Read as much as you want to about beauty; that will not fill your heart up with the realization of beauty. Keep reading; more and more reading will not bring you to an end of reading, and hence stillness. Knowledge fails there. It so miserably fails that after a point all it can say is that “I have failed.”

Then how does and where does the doubtless certainty about all that which makes life worth living come from? That comes from your meditateness. Because that comes from meditateness, it is not at all external, unlike knowledge which is always external and hence always prone to doubt.

Whatever has been told to you by an external agency will never become your life-blood. You will take it, store it, but yet there would be something foreign about it. You would never have complete faith upon it even if there is nothing to argue with. The knowledge may seem impeccable, the arguments that may have been presented to you may seem perfect, the logic behind everything may seem inviolable, and yet you will find that your heart is not being stilled, that you are not so sure about anything. That sureness arises only in meditation.

Let me put it this way: You attain your nature of sureness only in meditation. Then something magical happens there: knowledgeless knowing, which is so very difficult for a non-meditative mind to believe. You walk without legs. You fly without wings. You speak without knowledge. Have you ever spoken without knowledge? Only in meditation does that happen.

It is like flying without wings; it is the ultimate magic. You love without reason. You are joyful without looking for profit. Only this magic makes life worth it; otherwise, there is no point dragging on and on. The mind that lives only in theories, concepts, knowledge, and all of that quickly becomes conditioned. That mind somewhere is just waiting and preparing for death because life is then just a burden.

You are carrying so much load upon the head without a moment of rest. It is like working so hard without even getting paid; there is only agony and more agony. Going on living, working hard to feed the body, thinking so much to protect yourself, and getting not even a drop of that divine nectar which can make you forget all your tiredness. Tired day in and tired day out like a bonded laborer, working without remuneration, always trying to get security without ever being secure.

So, working so hard without ever getting that which you are working for. Always desperate for love without ever getting love—always desperate and never contented. Running from one place to the other like that proverbial deer in the mirage. Always thirsty, always thirsty, and just running around till he dies.

Look at the agony. That's how the normal mind and the common man lives: Like the thirsty deer hoping that the next promise of water will indeed materialize and quench his thirst. And it never materializes. You just keep running from here to there without ever reaching anywhere where you can stop. Stopping never happens.

Life without that meditateness is surely torture. Only in meditateness do you actually reach there where thought is attempting to reach all its life.

That is the difference between a thinking mind and a meditative mind. The thinking mind is all the time trying and never reaching; the meditative mind is so sure that it has no need to try. In its non-trying, it reaches a magical place where all is just known. How? Magically, reasonlessly, thoughtlessly. That cannot be explained. But you can have some taste of it if you are prepared to let go of your clinging to security. How much we tolerate just to secure ourselves. And what do we secure? Nothing except our chains; they are secured.

When from head to toe we are nothing but chains, even if we do secure something, what is it that we would secure? The chains. But how diligently do we secure our chains! We work so hard to maintain our fetters. The man has worked his entire life to build his own prison. There are some who save their entire life to dig their own graves and ensure that the graves are gold-plated or air-conditioned—you never know!

Have you heard of that? So, someone is walking on the highway, and someone comes to him and says, "Give me all your money, otherwise I will shoot you."

He says, "Let me think for a while."

Even the robber is amazed. He says, "Please do think. I want to see you thinking. You are the first man who has given me this reply!"

So, he thinks, and as happens with all the thinkers and as is the nature of the thought, he comes up with the most brilliant response to the situation. He says, "Alright. Shoot me."

The robber says, "Shoot I surely will. But tell me, how did you come to this conclusion? What was this tremendous thought process?"

He said, "See, this money that I have is for my security; it is tremendously important. Secondly, I will use this in my old age; it is for my future. Now, future and security are very important. Right now, you can

even shoot me—but how can I give up on security? Shoot me—but I can't give up my security. Kill me—but I can't give up on my future."

That is the brilliance of thought!

Remember, it is easy to laugh at it because it has been laid so bare in front of you, threadbare as they say. This is exactly what thought does in every situation. It wants nothing except security and continuation in time, future and security, except that no thinking process has any other objective. All thinking processes are towards *only* this objective. If you are vigilant enough, if you bother to inquire, you will find that out.

Whatever you are thinking is ultimately about securing the thinker. Thought has just one function: to secure the thinker. The thinker, by definition, is insecure. So, thought has just one function: secure the insecurity—and it does that perfectly. It secures your insecurity; it ensures that your insecurity continues.

Meditation is far beyond all this stupidity. You say, "I don't need to know what Truth is. I am alright. Who bothers to know?" Meditation says, "I have no need to get a definition of love." Meditation says, "No, no, don't explain to me what joy and peace are. It's okay. My memory is fairly poor. I don't need to load it. Even if you tell me, I will forget very soon. So, it's alright. I am okay. There are a lot of other things that we can do. The weather is nice; we can walk a little and if there is nothing else to do, we can just lie down and sleep. Why talk unnecessarily? What is this futile exchange of words, like armies exchange bullets? Why?"

It says this, but when the moment comes, the meditative mind finds that even without knowing as knowledge, it knows all that is essential. It knows without knowledge—so much so that it does not even have the knowledge that it knows.

Remember, not only is this knowing knowledgeless in the sense that it has not come from outside, it is knowledgeless even in the sense that it itself has no knowledge that it knows. So deep is its courage that when the moment comes, the knowing just shows up only to the extent it is needed and perfectly matched to the moment. It will not show up any more than what is needed and not an iota less than what is required.

It is like a magical pocket. You go to a shop without knowing how much there is in your pocket. When the moment comes to pay, you put your hand in your pocket, and only as much will be there as is needed to pay. But that pocket is available only to those who do not earn. Those who are great

earners and intent upon filling the pocket themselves do not get that magical pocket. Their pockets have only a little bit of money.

How much can you earn? There is no end to numbers. Whatever you will earn will be nothing if your net worth isn't multiplied by one thousand and a ratio is taken. You may have Rs. 1000. Multiply that by another one thousand and take that ratio—you have nothing. You may have a trillion dollars. Divide that by a trillion trillion dollars, and you have nothing. It is all comparative. In the thinking mind, there is anyway nothing except knowing by associating, knowing in a relative sense, knowing in a dualistic sense.

So, whatever we earn is anyway always insufficient. The magical pocket gives to you whatever you want without you even knowing that that much exists in your pocket. But for that there are a few conditions. The first one has already been stated: you should have not earned it; it should not have come from outside. Second, you will not decide to pick the challenges; you will be choiceless. You will not order the food depending on the money you have. You will not order a lot thinking that you have a lot of money, and you will not hold yourself back from eating assuming that you don't have much. You will order exactly as much as is needed. If you need a lot, order a lot, and if you don't need a lot, don't order a lot. You will get a sumptuous meal and you will eat to your heart's content. Then, fearlessly you will put your hand in the pocket and you will get the money.

For this, you require a lot of faith. Otherwise, you will keep wondering even while having your dinner that, "I might need to wash these utensils after eating. I am eating all this alright, but who knows, when I put my hand in the pocket, whether that sum, whether that amount will be available or not?" You need to have absolute faith. You need to have absolute faith that that much amount will be there.

And you cannot be greedy about it either. You cannot say that, "Alright, because anyway it is going to be available, so let me order twice the quantity that I need and also have something packed to show off elsewhere." Then you will put your hand and find nothing—and you will have to actually wash the utensils!

So, it is available—that magic, that blessing, that grace is available only to those who do not ask for it, who really do not need it, who are not greedy about it, and at the same time who value it so much that they will never say that we can get it from elsewhere or that we can earn it on our own.

You see, all of these are the functions of the thought. Thought acts exactly in these ways. "I can earn on my own. I can know. I can distribute it to others. I can get it from others. I can check what I know." All these are typical characteristics of thought. When these are not there, then where you are is called meditation, and greatness happens there.

It is difficult to share meditation in words. It is difficult to share the beyond knowing, the beyond knowledge, through the instrument of knowledge, so meditation cannot really be explained through words. Meditation can be shared, meditation can be explained only through meditation.

Now, Ashtavakra is saying, "The practice of meditation keeps one in bondage."

Why is he saying that? Because the method or technique for meditation cannot come through knowledge. Meditation surely does require a technique because it is the mind that ultimately relaxes, settles, and disappears into meditation; and mind moves only on techniques, so techniques are needed.

On the one hand, techniques are needed; on the other hand, Ashtavakra is saying, "The practice of meditation keeps one in bondage." What is this contradiction? The contradiction is that the technique for meditation too can be known *only* in meditation. It is your meditation, it is your meditateness which will automatically, from nowhere, reasonlessly tell you the right technique suited to you, and that technique cannot come from anywhere else. No book can tell it to you. No amount of thinking and planning and analyzing can tell it to you. You will just *know*.

When you are meditative, then you will also know how to live in a meditative way. This living in a meditative way itself is the technique for meditation. You will know whom to talk to, you will know what to read, you will know whom to avoid, and whom to come close to; you will simply know. The technique itself opens up when you are there. Otherwise, the technique will not be known to you. Otherwise, you will have all these borrowed practices of meditation, which are of very little help.

Understand it this way: What is happening here right now? We are talking about meditation, but even these words about meditation will be meaningful to you only if you are meditative. Only in your meditateness can you understand these words about meditation.

“Then what is the significance of these words if I already have to be meditative?”

Well, it is the words that are bringing you to meditation.

“And where are these words coming from?”

They are coming from meditation itself.

“Then what is the source of all this?”

Meditate and you will know. It is not a crude and linear cause-effect diagram. Do not come up with your chicken and egg story—what comes first, meditation or technique for meditation? Thought will not be able to understand all this. You understand what I say because you are meditative, and you are meditative because I say what I say.

“What comes first?”

Meditate!

“And what does meditation mean?”

Throw away this stupid question. When you throw away this stupid question, then you realize that meditation is sufficient. The answer to this question anyway does not matter. What will you do with the answer to this question? You will try to capture it. You will try to do things, some kind of mischief with it. What else will you do?

Ashtavakra is very right in saying that practices are a great barrier towards meditation. He is saying, “You are now and forever free, luminous, transparent, still. The practice of meditation keeps one in bondage.” Practice of meditation means acquired knowledge about meditation.

“What is meditation? How to go about doing it?” That will not help because the acquirer of that knowledge itself is the bondage. Knowing a few more practices, he reinforces himself. Gathering that knowledge, he does not dissolve; he becomes all the more cemented.

And that is the funniest game that *Maya* plays with us. The very same knowledge that is intended to treat us becomes an instrument of the disease. It requires a bit of the special, it requires a bit of grace, it requires an ambrosial touch for words to be really successful. Otherwise, in most of the cases, words are going to be co-opted. I am not very sure whether a recording of this session will be of any use to you. It requires something beyond words, maybe a particular presence for the words, to have any effect.

And that is what is wrong with meditation practices. They are mere words, things, methods expressed in words. The touch of the special is

missing; the aliveness is missing. They are like corpses. You look at a corpse and you look at a living man—there is not much of a difference on the outside. What is there? But everything is different. One is alive, one is dead.

Words are co-opted, and that is what I just said is one of the funniest games of *Maya*: that the very same words that are said to take care of illusions, to dissolve them, become an agent of illusion itself. You gather knowledge, and that knowledge only makes you more cunning and clever. Instead of dissolving the cleverness, it makes you all the more sophisticated in your cleverness—nuanced cleverness, subtle cleverness. Not a rough type of cleverness that can be easily seen, exposed, and hence dissolved, but a very fine cleverness.

Ashtavakra is advising that the practice of meditation keeps one in bondage. Yes, any practice that is not arising from meditation itself will keep you in bondage. The practice that will arise from meditation will be a practice touched by life; it will not be a dead practice.

The practices that we have are all dead practices. One takes up a practice and keeps on sticking to it; whereas, the practice that arises out of your meditateness will be a very dynamic practice. It will change every minute because life is a fresh movement every minute. The flow is not the same as it was a few seconds back, so the right action is not the same this moment as it was a few moments back. Hence, the meditation method for this moment must be different from what it was.

Kindly understand two things in this regard. One, you need meditation every moment. Meditateness is not something that you practice a fixed hour of the day. Secondly, you need a different method of meditation every moment. Your so-called conventional wisdom and gurus go against both of these. First of all, they have confined meditation to one of the activities of the day. Just like you have many other activities confined to their own time slots, similarly meditation too is an activity confined to its own time slot. No, meditation cannot be that; it has to be continuous. It has to be like breathing—continuous.

So, first, meditation has to be continuous. Second, the meditation technique, the method, the practice has to be very, very dynamic and flexible. You cannot keep employing the same method from morning till evening. It has to be so dynamic that nothing can be said about it. It has to be so flexible that it is a universal set, that it involves every possible action

that there can be. Walking is meditation, eating is meditation, talking is meditation, sleeping is meditation, running is meditation, anger is meditation.

Meditation is the universal set of whatever you do. Constant meditation—unhindered, unflinching, still and stable core. From that a lively flow of the right response to the moment. This right response itself is the meditation technique.

So, you are sitting here now and you are just sitting, listening. This is your meditation technique right now. What do you think, my words are benefitting you? No, it is your sitting that is important. If you could sit like this, exactly like this even without my words, then my words are simply not needed. I am redundant. It is your sitting that is important.

I am repeating: I may not be there, you may find that this place is vacant, but even then if you care about yourselves, just sit like this. It may be a little more difficult; maybe my presence helps it and facilitates it, but just sit like this as you are sitting right now and the same effect will be there. The session will be on; it is your sitting that matters. Conversely, if you are not sitting like this, then I may go on talking and talking, and yet there would be no meditateness.

So, what is happening? Your right response is the meditation technique. There is a particular moment, and you are doing what is right at that moment, and that is meditation. Someone knocks the door, and attentively you open the door; that is the meditation technique for that moment. As simple as that.

You are swimming in a river and you are swimming with all your presence; that is a meditation technique. But that meditation technique is not useful while sitting in a cinema hall. Sitting in a cinema hall, you require a different response to that moment, and that will be the right meditation technique for that moment. And where does that technique come from? Meditation itself.

I am repeating this: The right meditation technique can come from no place other than meditation. Not somebody else's meditation, not some guru's meditation; your own meditation. That is why people keep struggling with meditation; it has become such a puzzle. You have people teaching meditation and telling how difficult it is to meditate and this and that. It is because you are eating medicine that is not suited to you. The medicine that

is suited to you can come only from your own inner doctor; that is the magic of this.

You are the patient and you are the doctor, and only your own inner doctor can treat this patient. You go to an external doctor, he cannot help. The inner doctor is so flexible, versatile, and compassionate that he gives you dynamic prescriptions. Think of a doctor working so hard, every second he is giving you a fresh prescription, and his pharmacy is always open. Not only will he give you a prescription, he will also tell you it is available there free of cost. Go fetch it.

That is how this thing works—meditation, meditation technique. Do not be taken in by the complication of the word ‘technique’. Technique simply means right response to the situation of life. Sitting in a cinema hall is a situation of life. What to do there is the meditation technique. Somebody comes and abuses you, it is a life situation. What response should emanate is the meditation technique.

It is as simple as this and as difficult for the ego as this because in all this, there is no place for any kind of planning, cleverness, or manipulation. You have to surrender to the doctor. There is no place for your own knowledge that, “I went somewhere and read this. Doctor, I have read on the internet that these are the new medicines.” The doctor will refuse to talk. “You are so clever? You go and treat yourself!” Only when you just sit silent and say, “I don’t even need any medicine. Doctor, you are so beautiful; your presence is enough,” then the doctor starts treating you.

It’s a strange thing about meditation and about life. When you say, “I don’t want anything,” then suddenly the immensity of the unknown opens up to you.

“It is a little unjust!” No. Those who don’t want anything get everything, and those who are craving to get just get the craving and more of it. Yes, of course, you want more, you will get more. What? The craving.

“I don’t need to know”—and you know.

“I am so complete, I don’t feel lonely. I don’t need a partner”—and you find that the entire world is lovable. Searching for a special partner you only get a special search.

You get it when you are not demanding it. And, of course, you don’t demand it when you have it.

So, what comes first, the chicken or the egg? Just meditate. Don’t engage yourself in silly questions.

Q: Is there any difference between attention and meditation?

AP: Essentially the same used in different contexts. When dealing with the world in a meditative state, you are said to be in attention. But it is the same thing, just that it is used in a different context. In general, when you use the word 'meditation' you mean being centered. When you use the word 'attention' it means that you are dealing with the world with a particular quality of the mind. That quality is meditation.



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16.

How to know that one is meditating rightly?



Questioner (Q): I have two questions. Firstly, how does one know that one is meditating rightly? Secondly, I know that one should not be dependent on others and one's happiness should always come from within, yet my emotions erupt and I react due to the actions of the other person. So, how to stay detached from everything and stay unshaken in any situation?

Acharya Prashant (AP): Life is the only and ultimate proof. If your meditation is right then your life will be right. And if your life is right, then rest assured that knowingly, unknowingly, effortfully, effortlessly, you are meditating rightly.

Meditation the event, meditation the process, is a means. It is meant to give you a glimpse of what freedom is like. That glimpse has to then be nurtured. One has to fall in love with that glimpse. One has to say that one loves it so much that it is needed in all hours of life.

If that which comes to you in meditation does not remain with you continuously and throughout, then meditation is not only not successful but also dangerously counterproductive.

We will have to understand.

The peace experienced during a process of meditation is dualistic peace. Because you remain stressed and restless and filled up with unexpressed energy, so when a process of meditation, a method of meditation gives you relief from all that which is bothering you, then you feel great. That relief, that apparent peace, that dualistic peace, is experienced only because one is firstly full of stress.

That is why there are several methods of meditation that firstly require you to be full of stress. They take you to a peak of stress and from there they release you, so a calming effect, a soothing peace is experienced.

What is the difference between non-dual peace and dualistic peace? Non-dual peace has no opposite. Non-dual peace does not come after and

because of stress and tension. And non-dual peace does not leave you; you cannot experience it come and go. Dualistic peace is dependent on the experience of its opposite. Therefore, it is better called as relief rather than peace. So, the two are greatly different.

However, there is one commonality among them and that is a useful commonality. What is the commonality? In both, the experience of suffering disappears. Though the mechanism and dimension of the disappearance of suffering is vastly different in non-dual peace compared to dualistic peace, they both share one thing: suffering disappears.

In non-dual peace, there is a permanent relief from suffering, which means now you are at a point where you would never be affected by suffering; now you are at a point where there is complete security against suffering, complete and lasting. Whereas in dualistic peace, the peace is fragile. It comes as a great and welcome festivity, and sooner than later it deserts you as well.

So, then, what are the methods of meditation meant to do?

Dualistic peace is easier to be brought about: you only need to be greatly stressed and after that you will experience calmness. You don't have to pay a great price. You don't have to transform your life. You don't have to drop the ego. You don't need to be a great observer of the self. You don't even need to have a burning desire for liberation. You just need to be stressed out and then you will experience some welcome relief. A method has to be devised to temporarily bring down your level of anxiety—just temporarily.

So, the dualistic peace is a quick and economical introduction to freedom from suffering. Without paying the price, you are getting a glimpse. The glimpse is not quite the real thing; still, it is a useful pointer. The peace that one experiences in a process of meditation, in a method of meditation, is not real peace. But still, it is very useful. Why is it useful? Because it can stoke your hunger; because it can fuel your desire. Desire for?

Q: Liberation.

AP: Liberation. You say, “Now that I have a bit of taste, I am feeling much more hungry to get the whole meal.” That is the utility of methods of meditation. I am telling you both the utility and the limitations. The limitation is that what they give you is not quite the real thing; what you get from meditation is fleeting and dualistic peace. So, that's the limitation.

One's experiences during a process of meditation should not be taken extremely seriously. Those experiences, I repeat, are useful as pointers but they should not be given the status of the real thing. So, don't take them too seriously.

People become crazy after their experiences in this or that method of meditation. They get deluded; they start feeling as if Truth itself descends to them in their moments of meditation. It is not so, it is not so. But still, I am saying, all methods of meditations have their utility. And what is the utility? That they serve as teasers. They come and tempt you.

Now, somebody might be tempting you, somebody might be trying to attract you or seduce you, but you too must have a certain reciprocal feeling. Otherwise, all invitations will go waste.

You see, there is a tradition to send sweets along with the invitation to a wedding. So, you have been invited to a grand feast. The invitation card is there and the invitation card has reached you with a few sweets. And there are just too many people in this world who say, "What is the need to go to the party? The sweets have already been received!"

The sweets are not there to satisfy your hunger. They are there to whet your appetite—so that you can have more. But the method will not work on someone who says, "Fine! Sweets have been received. Why go to the party now?" What the fellow does not realize is that the party is far more grand. There is much more available there, offered there.

If one has become too accustomed to having just a little bit in life, if one has always received only a little, only the limited, then a few sweets are enough to satisfy him. Such a mind cannot enter the non-dual peace because first of all such a mind does not even want non-dual peace.

Look at the tragedy. The sweets were sent to lure you, they were sent to tempt you, and instead, you used the sweets as a sweet ploy to avoid the party.

And that is why sometimes I speak quite harshly against methods of meditation: because a very large number of people are using the methods of meditation to avoid real meditateness. They are using dualistic peace to stay away from real peace. Such a blunder is very commonly happening.

Now, you are asking how you can judge whether your meditation is right. I will give you a very honest, though a very brutal pointer. What to do? Honesty is brutal to most people!

That which you are in your moment of meditation, if you remain that throughout the day, then your meditation is right. Whereas, if after the hour of meditation your state changes, then your meditation is false.

As long as meditation is an activity distinct from your daily life, from your ordinary life, your meditation is false. If your meditation takes you away to a glorious land and then brings you back to your usual, ordinary circumstances, then your meditation is false.

So, when is meditation true?

Meditation is true when you can feel no difference between meditation and life. That's the test. You should be able to see no difference between meditation and life.

But quite the contrary happens. I have seen people crazily running after meditation—and why do they want meditation? Because there is a great difference between the hour of meditation and the rest of their life. So, to escape the ordinariness and the suffering and the boredom of their day-to-day lives, they then run towards meditation.

Don't get me wrong, but it is a bit like a drug addiction. People are even prepared to pay big sums to be led into specific methods of meditation. If one develops a habit towards a particular method then he will be prepared to pay with money and this and that and say, "Please, may I get to do that? How soon can we get to do that?" You must have come across such people.

What does this hunger for a particular method show? This hunger for a particular method shows that hunger for total meditateness is not there; one is satisfied with the sweets. The sweets have come with the invitation, but one is so happy with the sweets that one has rejected the invitation. The sweets have been accepted, the invitation has been rejected. How intelligent is that? And again and again one is asking just for sweets. The party is being avoided.

Meditateness does not give you a high. Real meditateness never gives you any special experience worth documenting. You will never be able to say, "I am feeling blissful due to meditation."

Please remember that experiences are all dualistic. To experience something, you must first be in its opposite state.

It is when the body is really hot that you most enjoy the blast of the air conditioner, don't you? Water is felt the most when it is either very hot compared to your body temperature or very cold compared to your body

temperature. Water at exactly the body temperature is hardly experienced, and not experienced at all if you are not thirsty at all.

It is the opposite state that experiences a state. Do you get this? Hot experiences cold. Restlessness experiences rest. In real non-dualistic meditateness, there is no swinging between extremes. Hence, there is no noteworthy experience.

Now, that makes real meditateness immensely invaluable and also absolutely non-marketable. Of immense value, but not marketable at all. Why? Because it cannot be experienced. If it cannot be experienced, what you are selling?

It is invaluable because it is your natural state.

It is invaluable because it gives life what life has been thirsty for.

It is invaluable because it is the highest that you can be.

But at the same time, it cannot be marketed because it is not a thing. It cannot be marketed because it is nothing specific. It cannot be marketed because its results cannot be shown. It cannot be marketed because it does not give you a high. It does not give you that orgasmic bliss.

So, are you doing meditation right? That's your question. I turn the question back upon you: Is your meditation something specific? Is your meditation something felt? Is your meditation something that you can put your finger on? Then your meditation is false.

Meditateness is throughout, continuous, uninterrupted. Life goes on and goes around in its usual circles, and at the center there is you, the meditator, the pure meditateness, meditation without the meditator. And things are just happening.

You are moving. You have not forced yourself to create extraordinary situations for the sake of meditation. You are not saying that you need music for meditation. You are not saying that you need a particular pose or *āsana*, or place for meditation. You are not saying that you need to halt your regular activity for the sake of meditation.

The usual affairs of life are going on and inside the cave sits the eternally meditating yogi. Outside the cave, there are the jungles and the cities and the rush of life. In the middle of the jungle is the cave and within the cave is the meditateness that no movement can touch or disturb or experience.

Methods of meditation are useful just as introductions, as invitations. Do not get wedded to a wedding invitation.

Q: If someone is meditating and his mind is not free from thoughts, then what one should do to free his mind from thoughts?

AP: Is your mind free of thoughts in your usual life? Why are you talking only of the moments when you are engaged in a special process?

That is why, I repeat, I sometimes condemn methods of meditation: because they prevent you from looking at your usual life. You get so focused on the method that you forget what you are doing otherwise and elsewhere. You are quoting a problem regarding your experiences in the meditation time. But why are you forgetting your problems outside of meditation time? It is the same mind, is it not?

When you are not living rightly, how do you expect your meditation to be perfect? You cannot be a tendency-driven, influence-driven, thought-driven individual 23 hours of the day and then ask me, “Why do thoughts interfere when I am trying to meditate?” Because 23 hours of the day you are just practicing thoughts and tendencies, so how can they suddenly disappear in the one hour of the meditation exercise? The exercise is bound to fail.

You see, yesterday I was saying spirituality is about reducing your burden, reducing your load, and letting the mind be lighter. We said the innocent traveler travels light. Dropping the baggage is important.

I asked my gym trainer, “How does one lose weight?” He said it is 75% diet and 25% exercise. By exercising a lot you cannot outdo the effects of what you have been eating throughout the day. You can't out-exercise a bad diet and I am saying you can't out-meditate a bad life. How much time does one spend in the gym? One hour at the most. 23 hours you are just gorging food in this endless cave and then one hour you go and say, “I will out exercise all the rubbish I have taken in.” It is not going to happen.

Similarly, if you have been living badly and you think that you will be able to meditate and compensate for the wrong choices, the wrong company, the wrong food, the wrong intake, the wrong influences, then you are not going to succeed. Remember, it is 75% diet. You have to ask yourself: What am I allowing in? That's what diet is, right? What am I allowing in my life?

The gym trainer talks of the diet that you take in through the mouth. The teacher of meditation must talk of the diet that you take in through the senses. What is it that you are looking at? What is it that you are thinking about? What is it that you are listening to? Whose company are you

keeping? That's 75% of it, and that is what you have to mostly keep in mind. Why am I living? Whose face am I seeing day and night? How liberated are the ones I live with?

If the ones you live with are themselves prisoners, how are you going to move towards liberation? Is that going to happen?

If you live with foodies, it is going to be tremendously difficult to diet. It is not impossible, but it is going to be very, very difficult. The entire house is full of food of all the titillating varieties and you are saying that you are on a diet. Now, try that. Try that!

So, you tell me, how you are living your life. Instead, you are asking me what is the absolutely correct yoga posture for meditation. That question is not useful, not relevant. It becomes relevant only after the fundamentals have been taken care of. You get this?

Q: Meditation also talks about raising the level of consciousness. How is that related to peace?

AP: What is consciousness? That which goes around your head is consciousness. Simple! That which you keep experiencing; that which you keep thinking of; that which comes and goes, rises and falls; that which is remembered and forgotten—all that is consciousness. In other words, the ocean of the mind with all its waves and depths is consciousness.

So, you remembered somebody; this is an act in consciousness. You forgot somebody; that too is an act in consciousness. You think, you analyze, you visualize, you imagine—all that is consciousness.

Now, tell me, what is meant by a lowly consciousness and high consciousness? What is meant by pure and impure consciousness? Tell me, please.

Okay. Consciousness always has two. Which two?

Q: Observer and the observed object.

AP: And who is the observer? The one that you take yourself to be. So, consciousness always has two. Our consciousness is always dualistic. In all your thoughts you are present, are you not?

Q: Yes.

AP: You are the thinker. Consciousness always has two and out of these two, you are always the subject. The second one is the object, right? Now, of these two, which one is central? The subject. Why? Because the object changes according to the subject.

So, suppose in the consciousness of five of you, this curtain is present. Apparently, the same object is present in the consciousness of five people, but not all five will be perceiving it in the same way. Why? Because the subjects are different. So, consciousness is two—the subject and the object. You are the subject and the object too depends on the...?

Q: Subject.

AP: So, fundamentally the quality of consciousness is the quality of the subject. We are trying to discover what is pure or high consciousness.

So, the quality of the consciousness is the quality of the 'I', the subject that you are, right? Now, this 'I' could either be the images about 'I' that one carries—it could be a manufactured 'I', a cultured 'I', a cultivated 'I', a social 'I', a biological 'I', a historical 'I', an influenced 'I', or it could be somebody else. Who that 'I' is decides the quality of consciousness.

If your 'I' has been manufactured over time, if your 'I' is the result of a thousand influences and therefore a thousand contaminations, then your 'I' will be called an impure 'I'. A lot of things have become mixed in the 'I', so the 'I' is now fit to be called impure. So many things have become identified with 'I', one with 'I', conflated with the 'I', that the real 'I' is nowhere to be seen. That is an impure consciousness.

The thinker does not know who is thinking and therefore thought itself is hazy and confused. That is impure consciousness. The looker does not know who is looking and therefore whatever he looks at is blurred. He does not get to know what the world really is. He just keeps projecting the world.

And remember, the tendency to project increases as the contamination increases. The more contaminated your mind, your consciousness is, the more you will be prone to project. You understand 'projection'? Not seeing what is, rather visualizing it, imagining it, projecting it.

What does meditation have to do with elevation of consciousness? An impure consciousness results in a lot of restlessness. Impurity of consciousness, identification of 'I' with a thousand things, and restlessness—these go hand in hand. Why does the 'I' become restless when the 'I' is impure? It is easy to understand.

If the 'I' is composed of influences from the world, then the 'I' remains insecure, because 'I' is the fundamental unit, 'I' is who you are, and you want to exist. Existence is your nature. You don't just want to disappear. But you, the 'I', is coming from the world and the world is always rising,

falling, appearing, and disappearing. So, now you sense danger. What is the danger? That you too will disappear along with the world.

Please understand. If the 'I' is not independent then the 'I' is threatened. If the 'I' is independent then nothing in the world can harm it, defeat it, or vanish it.

But if, let's say, your 'I' depends on this wall, 'I' depends on the wall—that's impure consciousness, right? 'I' is now dependent on something—and you see that the wall is now being harmed, what happens to the 'I'? Then 'I' feel as if it is being harmed; every blow to the wall is a blow to the 'I'. The 'I' becomes restless.

So, impure consciousness and restlessness go together. Conversely, peace and pure consciousness go together. The more peaceful you are, the more centered you are in yourself and the less dependent you are.

Peace and freedom are, therefore, synonymous. Dependence on something is restlessness, because that thing is a worldly thing and nothing in the world has permanence.

So, dependence leads to restlessness, therefore peace and independence go together. Dependence is restlessness, so independence is rest—which is peace. Is that clear?

Now, if a process of meditation is giving you a glimpse of peace, restfulness, then it is also giving you independence, freedom. Because we said peace and independence go together: the moment you are peaceful you are also independent, and to be independent is to be in an elevated state of consciousness.

Q: Do meditation and *samādhi* (dissolution) go hand to hand?

AP: *Samādhi* just means peace. *Samādhi* is peace.

The second part of the question is: “How to stay detached from everything and stay unshaken in any situation caused by any individual?”

You need to probe the relationship between you and the world, you and all individuals, you and any particular individual. That relationship needs to be investigated. If you are dependent on someone, you will not be able to remain unshaken. You cannot ask for both. You cannot ask for comforts that come with dependency and peace that comes with independence. You have to decide what it is that you really love. That love is the central thing.

This morning itself I read:

”*Yoga kuyog, gyan agyaanu, jahan nahin Ram prem pradhunu.*”
Without love, *yoga* is *kuyog* and *jñāna* is *ajñāna*.

You have to decide what is it that you really love. Without love for freedom, all your meditation exercises will just remain antiques and acrobatics; you are jumping around shouting this and that. It is love that turns an activity of meditation into meditateness. Love!

"Yoga kuyog, gyan agyaanu, jahan nahin Ram prem pradhnu." If you don't have love for the real thing, then keep trying your yoga; it is not going to work. It is only going to sink you further. And if you don't have love for real things, then keep filling yourself with knowledge, keep reading as many books as possible, keep listening to sermons; you aren't reaching anywhere.

Is your being full of love? That's the question to ask.

Are you prepared to leave, sacrifice everything for love? That's what you must answer.



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17.

Why does meditation not succeed?



Questioner (Q): While meditating I feel silence and joy for some time, but after a while I am not able to continue; I start feeling uneasy and want to come out of the meditation. Why does this happen, and does it mean that I am not reaching the meditative state?

Acharya Prashant (AP): What are you doing and *why* are you trying to do that?

You try several things in life for the sake of peace, don't you? You have said, while meditating you feel silence and joy for some time, which means silence and joy are your objectives. With these same objectives, you do many other things—and is the result not the same usually? Always?

You get into something, you pursue it, and then you lose the motivation, then you come out of it. One visits a new place; the place seems attractive for two days, four days, one week, one month, one year—the place loses its charm.

You must have discarded, kept away, or donated old clothes. How did it feel when you were buying those same clothes? There was an attraction, a hope. There was a glimmer in the eye; you were looking forward to wearing new clothes. Then came a moment when you just put them aside.

That's the nature of all human activity. That's the nature of everything in life. That's the world—it does not last. Nothing here lasts; everything here is within the confines of time. The clock is continuously ticking.

So, you eat, and then a point comes when you leave the table. You play, and then a point comes when you leave the field. You are born; a point comes when you leave the sense of being alive. Is there anything that has ever beaten time? You eat, you leave the table; you mate, you leave the bed; you meditate, and then you leave the mat. Why are you worried? What were you thinking? What were you hoping?

You aren't doing anything wrong; you are just in the domain where only this happens and *only* this can happen. If you hope for something else, then you do not understand where you are.

It is like tossing a ball up and then finding it come back to you and wondering, “What did I do wrong?” You didn’t do a thing wrong. You very rightly tossed it up but you tossed it up within the field of gravitation, and within that field of gravitation whatever goes up, comes down. So, why are you so worried?

You can toss a piece of stone up; it will come down. You can toss a diamond up; it will come down. You can toss a copy of the greatest scripture up; it will come down. A piece of cloth comes down. You toss a man up, even the man will come down. If an entire mountain could go up, the mountain too would come down. It is not a matter of form, size, color.

Within the field of the world, all things are *Prakriti*, all things follow certain laws.

Within the field of activity, whatever you will do will have but this consequence: sooner than later you will have to stop the activity because there was a point when you initiated the activity.

If meditation for you is something that can start at some point, it is going to end at some point. It is no wonder that it ends, but it is a great wonder that you hope that it will never end. Why will it never end? Was it birthless for you? Then how would it be deathless? Did it never start for you? Then how is it not going to ever end?

You do not find it painful when you start your meditation at 7 a.m. Nobody ever complained to me about that! “Why does my meditation start at 7 a.m.?” But you find it very painful when your meditation ends at 8 a.m. If it is going to start at 7, it is going to end at 8. Is that not very straightforward? About 8 a.m. you are not only worried but actually sad. “Why do I come out of my great meditative state?” How did you enter your great meditative state? And if you can enter it, you will have to come out of it.

Is there anything that you have entered and never come out of? Anything?

He (*referring to an audience member*) got into this kurta and if he doesn’t come out of it, none of us would want to go near him. Sooner than later, he will have to come out of it, and then there will come a point when he will have to come out of this body as well. There is this room, we all got into it. Anybody here who would never come out? So, enjoy as long as you are here, that’s all.

Everything is going to end. Everything starts just to end.

What's troubling you? Oh, probably you thought you could enter into That which would never end. No, that won't happen. You cannot enter into That which would never end. If that is the expectation, you would be disappointed.

One cannot enter That.

I know teachers, scholars, gurus, *jñānis*, have all spoken that language. "Come, enter the Truth. Come, move into God." Let me say with all humility and with no pretension of righteousness that all that is nonsense. You can never, never move into Truth.

All movement is in the field of consciousness, all movement is in the field of *Prakriti*. You get in, you get out; you get in, you get out. God is not *Prakriti*, God is not consciousness. In the Truth, there is no movement; in the Truth, there is no door to enter and there is no exit either.

Nobody enters the Truth ever; nobody attains the Truth ever; nobody got anything in a spiritual pursuit ever.

You are trying to look for a vacuum in the field of gravitation. How will you find it? You can find all things in the domain of things, right? You can find all things in the domain of things, but if your expectation is to find the great, great nothing, then you are searching at the wrong place, in the wrong domain. Nothing but frustration is what you would get.

That's one big rubric we all need, a big neon signboard flashing all the time and it must read: "You will not get it here."

All this meditation business is a big hoax. "Enter into joy, enter into silence, feel peaceful." Of course, you will feel peaceful. Feelings can be manipulated.

The AC of my car is not functioning and my driver ran away. I drove to this place, then I rushed up the stairs. And it is hot; it is the month of May in India. Now, here, the AC is there, the fan is there, and I am sitting comfortably. I am no more a driver now; I am Acharya Ji, and I am feeling peaceful. That's how superficial feelings are.

That's one big industry—feelings. One big myth—the value of feelings. Anybody can change your feelings. See how peacefully you are sitting here and how meditative you are. All your feelings would change if there is a power cut or if the fan drops on your head. It is not Godliness that is making you feel peaceful, it is sheer comfort to the body and mind.

And even if no physical calamity happens, just one unsettling piece of news is enough to change your feelings right now, is it not? What will

happen to all your meditation then, when all of you are looking so meditative right now? Acharya Ji is pouring forth on Vivekachudamani and see how meditatively the listeners are sipping it, and somebody comes and says, “You know, your cat is missing.” And then joy and silence and peace...

Is that what you want—to feel good? You can be *made* to feel good. There are millions and billions who want to feel good and who are acting to make others feel good. It does not take much to make someone feel good. Some good food, some lotion on the ego, a pep talk, a motivational juice, some money—or at least a promise of money—ah, sex! Or if you are of the religious bent, then some *bhajan kirtan*! You will feel good.

They come and go, these feelings. And if you are meditating to feel good, then you are just deceiving yourself—deceiving yourself only if you want something eternal, only if you want something that lasts. If you just want a bit of titillation, entertainment for some time, then you are not deceiving yourself; then your meditation can very easily give you joy and silence.

Various people look towards various objects for pleasure. Diverse minds, diverse objects. One can find the so-called silence object pleasurable, one can find the so-called peace object pleasurable, especially if silence and peace have been greatly advertised, especially if one knows what silence and peace are because the images of silence and peace have been supplied in advance. One can find them highly pleasurable and respectable.

It is a noble pursuit, ‘meditation’, is it not? After all, one is not chasing money, one is not doing any of those immoral things, one is not indulging in ostensible violence; one is just sitting down calmly and meditating. It is very easy to make oneself feel good. Before meditation, you were what you were; after meditation and during meditation, you still are what you are, but feeling good.

Before meditation, if you are stupid, you are just stupid. During meditation, you are peacefully stupid! I don’t deny the fact of peace, you have that peace—that peace which is advertised, that peace that can be known through facial expressions, that peace which is more material than material. You can tell a peaceful person, don’t you? Can’t you? “See, he is peaceful.” Why? “He is not fidgeting much, his face is not carrying emotional expression,” so you start calling him peaceful.

One can be very peaceful—and stupidly so.

What am I saying? I am saying that the center does not change. If the center is stupid the center remains stupid, and on that stupid center one wears a veneer of peace. So, one is now stupidly peaceful; the stupidity hasn't gone away anywhere. If the center is violent it is remaining violent, and on that violent center one is now wearing a coat of peace and joy and silence, all those things that you are talking of here in the question.

So, one remains violently peaceful. So, before meditation one was just violent, and during meditation one is violently peaceful. The peace is there, but that does nothing to the center; it comes and goes, the center remains. Ah! Even the center is not eternal. It is not eternal because it is possible to dissolve that center.

But the center still has great longevity; at least it is much more permanent than these episodes of peace. Peace is so easy to dislodge, is it not? The violent center, the stupid center, is not easy to dislodge or dissolve; it remains. Proceeding from that center one can continue to meditate till eternity; nothing will change.

Ashtavakra is talking to Janaka. In the very first chapter he tells him, "Dude, you are already good. Your only problem is that you meditate." That's Ashtavakra for you. Very clearly he says, "Your only problem is that you are practicing meditation. *Samadhi ka abhyāsa*. Stop that and everything is alright with you." What does it mean when it is said that 'everything is alright with you'? What it means is that things are as they are, mind is as it is, body is as it is.

Liberation is a disease of the mind because by seeking liberation the mind is wanting something that it is not given to want, that it is not supposed to want. It is arrogance. The mind is trying to go beyond its mandate, beyond its brief. That which is supposed to remain in time is trying to act as the one who is timeless. What else is ego?

You are trying to experience the Truth. Go into that statement. You are trying to feel peaceful. Go into this statement. What is the mind trying here when you say, "I want to experience the Truth," or "I want to feel peace"? What is the mind trying? That which must remain in limits, in time, is trying to put its hands on eternity, the limitless, the timeless. This is ego.

And the center is not being dislodged, mind you. The mind is not saying that "I am prepared to go away." The mind is saying, "I must be there." What is the proof that the mind does not want to go away? The proof

is that the mind is insisting on experience. If the mind goes away, who will be the experienter?

So, the mind is saying, “I want to remain, I want to experience; I want to remain as the experienter, and I also want the Truth and peace and I want to taste them. I want to taste them!” This is horrible. It is like trying to gate crash into heaven.

God has laid down certain conditions, certain qualifications. There are some restrictions on entry, and the ego is saying, “I will get there without fulfilling the entry requirements. I will gatecrash.” God is saying, “You want to come to me? You will have to perish. Perish and come!” And the meditator is saying, “I will remain and I will barge into the God land, and I will then experience the Truth, I will then experience peace and fulfillment.”

It is almost like trying to rape. Do you sense the same instinct? “I want to experience that which is forbidden. I want to get into the proscribed territory.” It is nothing but Adam defying God and deciding to taste the apple. “I will get there and I will get there on my own terms.”

Meditation is like backdoor entry into the land of God. It is like flying without a visa. “I will get there without fulfilling the entry requirements.” The entry requirement is simple: your life must be Godly. That’s the entry requirement. 24 hours you have to be the one who bothers for nothing but the One. That is, to you, too tough a requirement to handle. You will say, “That kind of price I don’t want to pay.”

So, what is the device you come up with? Meditation.

You say, “Fine, half an hour every day, if I sit down on the yoga mat in an air-conditioned room and close my eyes and do various kinds of antics, that’s not a bad deal at all. God is demanding too high a price! He’s saying I can’t be myself any point in the day. He’s saying that the personal must totally evaporate. He’s saying I must be like a slave, like a machine. I don’t want to agree to that. I love God, it’s just that I love myself more. I am not a God hater, it’s just that self-love is too hard to resist.”

And from There the commandment is: ‘Be mine all the time.’

“All the time? Who has that much time? One is here for 60 years, 80 years. If I am yours all the time, then who will experience all these pleasures? God is alright, but there are other beautiful things as well. Nobody denies that God is good, but is God the only one who is good?” No, that kind of absolute respect we don’t want to offer.

“You are good, but then there are, you know, others as well. And especially at times when your goodness is not very visible, then others come up as even more tempting. God is good, but he does not always appear to be good, and in those times there are so many others who just pop up: ‘Hey! Hi!’ And the bugger up there is saying, ‘Be mine all the time.’ Not done!

“And if you want me to be yours all the time, would you offer a reciprocal arrangement? Would you send me proof that you too are mine all the time? There has to be some parity after all!”

And the fellow says, “Forget parity! I don’t belong to anybody, but you have to belong to me.” This one down here is an intellectual, a liberal, a believer in equality, and he says, “This is not done, I can *think* of belonging to you, but then you have to convince me that you too belong solely to me.”

No reply comes from There. And then the decision is straightforward:

“If you have your own sweet will to live by, I too have my own personal priorities. It’s not that I will expel you from my world; 7 a.m. to 7:30 a.m. every day will belong to you. But then, the world is full of so many other delicacies; I must honor them. There are colors and balloons and men and women and money and crackers and—there’s so much! And God, it’s your creation; it has got to be as beautiful as you are, how can I deny it? Disrespecting your creation would be disrespect towards you. After all, was it not you who sent all these to me?”

So, it’s 11 a.m. right now and it’s all about balloons and crackers. Where is your meditation at 11 a.m.? And if meditation is so ultimately important to you, why don’t you meditate 24 hours? And if meditation is not important enough to be had 24 hours, why are you asking me a question on meditation as if meditation is important?

If meditation is important, why do you get out of it? Why don’t you keep meditating 24 hours? You will now say, “But you see, one has to, you know, take care of... (*imitates a nervous laughter*). There are itches in the body and, you know, let’s talk practical.” Why? I thought we were talking spiritual! From where has this practicality leapt in?

If meditation is so very dear to you, why don’t you meditate 24 hours? And if it is not dear to you, then why are you asking a question as if meditation is dear to you? Just accept that it is one of your daily activities, and if it is one of your daily activities, then it starts and it ends. That’s the

domain of this world, that's what happens to everything in this world: it starts and it ends. Your meditation also starts and ends.

If you want something that never ends, just don't end it. Just don't end your meditation. It is *you* who decides to end the meditation, right? Or is it God? Who decides to get up?

Q: We decide.

AP: You. And now you are asking, "Why does silence cease? Why is peace interrupted?" Why do *you* get up? If sitting on that mat is what meditation is all about, why do you ever get up? Either keep sitting on that mat, or never begin with this farce.

That which you call as the practice of meditation is a tool, is a method. It is a short-lived method to bring to you the taste of the beyond. The taste of the beyond comes for free.

There is this fellow, a lady rather, who was selling all kinds of *namkeens* (Indian snacks) at IHC (Indian Habitat Center), 50 kinds of different things she was having. So, I went to her shop. I said, "What is that you have?" She immediately offered me one little piece of the *namkeen*. She said, "Take it," so I tasted it. She didn't charge me anything for it. That's meditation.

But once you have tasted it and liked it, then it is your responsibility to pay for it. That half an hour is free; you are not paying with your life for that half an hour. You haven't paid the price, you haven't made any sacrifice; you are comfortably sitting down on the mat.

That little episodic experience is offered for free. But having had that experience, now it is your responsibility to pay up, and now the payment must continue 24 hours. If you keep standing in front of that woman and say, "Now this, now that; now this, now that," and you are doing this since one month, what do you think she will give you? A hush, a push, and one tight slap, maybe. She will see through your intentions; she will realize that you are just a professional meditator. You don't love God; you just want some goody experience for free. You have no intention to pay up.

So, I am not against that thing that you do for 30 minutes on the mat; that's good as a beginning, as a trailer. Begin with that, but that must tell you that you can never now part with that.

Having just had a fleeting taste of something beyond you, now it is your responsibility to make that beyondness the center of your life. The existing center has to be dislodged.

Instead, what is it that you are doing? Every morning you go to that woman—and now it is a habit and a cunning conspiracy with you—and she has 50 kinds of boxes and you tell her, “Now this, now this, now this,” and very deceptively you are having your breakfast without paying up.

Oh, she is a simple woman, you can probably deceive her for a month. How long will you deceive God? Will he not see through your stupid designs? Will he not realize that “This man has no intention of coming to me. All he wants is his 30 minutes of exotic experience. This man has really no intention of coming to me, this man has no intention of sacrificing himself for my sake. What does he want? Daily 30 minutes of exotic experience”—and that you can continue to get.

Obviously, you sit down in a particular posture and you insulate yourself from distractions; you ensure that the temperature is nice and your family members know that at this point you are to be spared, and you have kept your phone away and there is some nice aroma as well and you have already taken a bath, so you are feeling nice. You have ensured all the physical requirements are taken care of, all the things that go towards pleasure. All the boxes are ticked.

So, obviously, you will have a good experience. If that is what you want, continue with this meditation. Otherwise, the practice of meditation should very soon turn into incessant meditateness. The practice must come to an end and meditateness must take over the totality of your life. Every breath, every action, every thought, must now originate from your meditateness.

One who begins the practice of meditation has succeeded only if a point comes when he starts finding the practice of meditation unnecessary, and he says, “Now this is not needed. Now that which used to come to me in these 30 minutes is more totally, more wholly, and more continuously with me all through the day.” Then your meditation is real; otherwise, you are just going to the woman and trying to deceive her. You don’t want to pay up and you still want to have some experience.

And some experience you definitely get, I am not denying that. Some experience you get, but how much? One piece of *kaju* (cashew), a little bit of this or that, one small modicum of papad—does that satisfy you? This much?

If you want the whole thing, then you have to pay up. So, pay up and get the whole thing. And without that wholeness, life is not worth living.



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18.

The myth of meditation and concentration

(Advait Bodhsthal, 2018)



cittamūlo vikalpo'yaṁ cittābhāve na kaścana
ataścittaṁ samādhehi pratyagrūpe parātmani

This apparent universe has its root in the mind, and never persists after the mind is annihilated. Therefore dissolve the mind by concentrating it on the Supreme Self, which is thy inmost Essence.

~ Vivekachudamani, Verse 407



Questioner (Q): In verse 407 of Vivekachudamani, it is advised to “dissolve the mind by concentrating it on the Supreme Self, which is thy inmost Essence”.

Is this ‘inmost Essence’ the same as the ‘I am’, the natural sense of being felt in the Heart? If so, is it enough to fix the attention on this, both in my meditations and as I go through the day, bringing the attention back every time it wanders away? Would that kind of concentration be sufficient or is something more required?

Acharya Prashant (AP): The flower can never quite feel the root, or can it?

You have talked of the ‘I am’, the natural sense of being felt in the Heart. Whatsoever is felt is always felt in the mind. The Heart is that which

enables the feeling, but in the Heart there are no feelings nor can the Heart be ever felt.

Meditation is not about concentrating on the natural sense of being. Meditation is not about bringing the mind back from the world to some 'I am' idea. To meditate is to continuously look for that for which the eyes anyway are looking.

You must understand this.

Look at the way one's eyes look. We don't just look; we look purposefully, don't we? The eyes keep on looking. The ears keep on hearing. The mind keeps on processing. The memory keeps on accumulating. One keeps on living. One keeps on breathing. None of that is just happening. For us, all of that is happening with a purpose.

The eyes are looking for something. The mind is processing, traveling, running in order to reach somewhere. That's what the human being is all about: a dislocation trying to find its home.

You don't have to bring your mind back from the world to yourself because there is nothing called 'yourself'. The mind will anyway not be able to look at the Truth beyond its own dimension; the mind is not configured to do that.

You don't have to retreat from the world. You don't have to shrink away from the world. You just have to remember that when the eyes are looking at something, they are also trying to look at something beyond that something—and that is why no thing ever suffices.

Just remembering this is sufficient. And what's more, you don't even need to remember this much, because the very movement of the eyes is anyway a continuous reminder that you are hungry.

To meditate is to keep your one aim as your *only* aim.

When you are somewhere—and as a physical being, as a personal body, you would always be somewhere in the world. When you are somewhere, look fully into where you are. That fullness is what you are looking for, please understand. That is meditation.

If you are fully looking at the world, that fullness is what you are looking for and what you are looking at and where you are looking from. Be fully in the world. Don't escape, don't run away. Don't try to go somewhere else.

If you can know the reality of what you are seeing with your eyes, hearing with your ears, thinking of with your mind, that is meditation.

To meditate is to be continuously in love with the Truth. That is meditation. I repeat, your eyes will not look at the Truth; that is not a power given to them. But let your eyes truthfully look. That choice is available to you. Exercising that choice rightly is meditation.

Now, what does verse 407 say? “Dissolve the mind by concentrating it on the Supreme Self, which is thy inmost Essence.”

The mind remains concentrated anyway, but do note the objects of your concentration. Fear concentrates you, greed concentrates you, do they not? If there is a fearsome object in front of you, you feel great concentration, don't you? A black cobra in your room—you would be fully concentrated, wouldn't you? An attractive scene in a movie—you are fully concentrated. A lucrative business idea—you are concentrated. Possibility of the fulfillment of desire—you are concentrated.

And different people are concentrated on different things because the desires are different. Your desire decides your concentration, doesn't it? What you are desirous of, that you would be concentrated upon. Deeper the desire, the deeper the concentration.

But the mind is a fool because desire is blind. Desire does not know what it really desires, so it moves in blind directions. And therefore, all concentration is false. You can concentrate only upon that which you *think* will fulfill you—and that which you think will fulfill you never really fulfills you.

So, concentration doesn't help. Hence, it is not a matter of concentrating even more; it is a matter of seeing the futility of concentration. When Shankaracharya is saying, “Dissolve the mind by concentrating it on the Supreme Self,” then it has to be read with care and caution. What he is saying is that a mind concentrated in random and miscellaneous stuff will never dissolve.

Please appreciate what is being said. Shankaracharya says, “Dissolve the mind by concentrating it on the Supreme Self.” But the mind is never really concentrated on the Supreme Self; it is always concentrated on all the worldly and miscellaneous things, is it not? It is beyond the mind to concentrate on the Truth because the Truth is not an object.

So, effectively what Shankaracharya is saying is this: concentration will not help. Effectively what Shankaracharya is saying is: your mind is anyway always concentrated and the type of concentration that you have

will not help. Does that mean that the mind has to be concentrated somewhere else? No.

This verse is, then, a critique of concentration. This verse just tells you that whatsoever you are concentrating on is going to disappoint you.

Concentration is synonymous with fear and desire, and fear and desire are fake methods to gain fulfillment. Desire tells you, "Follow me and you will gain fulfillment." And fear tells you, "Follow me and you will retain fulfillment. If you do not follow me, your fulfillment would be snatched away." That's what fear tells you.

Shankaracharya is saying, "Your concentrations are useless. Do not concentrate." And when you gain the strength to not concentrate upon the objects of your desire, then rest assured that you are concentrating on your Supreme Self.

You will never directly know that you are concentrating on the Supreme Self. It is only when you become a little light, a little indifferent, a little casual about the objects that you value so much that you can indirectly realize that you are getting the fruits of concentrating on the True Self.

I repeat, concentrating on the True Self is not directly possible. Mind concentrates and concentrates only on the false. Therefore, when you see the futility, the falseness of your prevailing concentrations, it is then that you are concentrating on the Truth. In other words, concentrating on the Truth enables you to not concentrate on the false.

But it is here that the effect will tell about the cause. You cannot use the cause to generate the effect. You cannot say, "When I will concentrate on the Truth, then I will forget all about the false." No, this kind of a cause-effect relationship does not apply to the Truth. Why will it not apply to the Truth? Understand that.

You are saying, "When I will concentrate on the Truth, then I will give up the false." In other words, you are trying to cause the cause. What is the effect according to you? Obliteration of the false. And what is the cause that will generate that effect according to you? Concentrating on the Truth. So, you want to concentrate on the Truth; you are trying to generate the cause. In other words, you are trying to cause the cause. That is foolish.

Truth is the first cause, Truth is the primal cause, and Truth itself is uncaused. How can you cause the uncaused? Therefore, don't try ever to concentrate on the Truth. That is not meditation. Unfortunately, that is what is going around in the name of meditation. That is not meditation.

Meditation is when you look at your existing desires and the resulting concentration. That looking *itself* is a blessing of the Truth. Seek no further. Don't try to know any further. Beyond that is not the realm of knowledge; you won't be able to know. Just accept the grace. Grace has arrived. You will never be able to know how and from where.

It is a strange thing. The cause is not in your hands, the effect is. How is that so? Because you are the one who has a choice. You have a choice with respect to the effect. Which effect are we talking of? Concentration is the effect.

You can either concentrate and give a lot of importance to your desires, or you can decide to take yourself lightly; you can decide to not give too much value to your desires, to your tendencies, to your proclivities. That is where your choice and your power lies.

The mind is concentrating. Do you want to side with the mind? If you want to side with the mind, then side with the mind! The mind is your God. Or you may decide to take the mind with a pinch of salt, a bit casually. The moment you make that decision, you are blessed.

Does that mean that your decision is causing the cause? Does that mean your decision is fetching you the blessings? Yes and no both. It is a freedom that you have.

You are fully free to concentrate as per your ideas. The skies will not come crashing down. Do whatever you want to do, the Truth remains as it is. You keep doing whatever you want. Or you may decide that the mind is a fickle thing, not to be given much importance.

You may ask, "From where does this difference in decision come?" You will never be able to know. You will never be able to know what causes a person to choose rightly and another one to choose foolishly. You will not be able to know the source of wisdom.

You can at most pray. You can at most wonder. Maybe wondering would help. Maybe wondering is what one calls as inquiry. Maybe wondering rather than thinking or ideating is the purest form of inquiry.

Don't look elsewhere. Look where you are, see what you are doing. And pray that you get the power to reject the falseness in yourself, in your thoughts, in your actions. That's all, and that is meditation.



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19.

Liberation, meditation, Heart, and free will

(Rishikesh, 2019)



Questioner (Q): Acharya Ji, what is liberation?

Acharya Prashant (AP): What is bondage? There is nothing called liberation, nothing at all. It's just that because there is bondage, hence there is liberation. In the absence of bondage you are liberated from liberation as well.

Q: Is meditation the only way to attain liberation?

AP: What is meditation? If meditation means challenging your bondages, then yes; if meditation means doing this and that, then no.

Q: Does liberation mean that we are free from all the responsibilities?

AP: First of all, you cannot use the word 'responsibility' in the same breath, in two different dimensions. That which we keep on doing on a daily basis, if that is what is to be called as responsibility, then liberation is no responsibility at all. And if liberation is the real responsibility then there can be no other responsibilities.

You cannot say that you are responsible for meeting your quarterly sales target and you are also responsible for your liberation. Choose the word carefully.

Q: Why is it so easy to fall into bondage?

AP: It is attractive and it carries the name of liberation. Let bondage come to you honestly declaring that it is bondage, and then we will see whether bondage attracts you. Because you are a great lover of liberation, therefore bondage manages to dupe you.

You are an innocent lover, ready to be beguiled. So, bondage comes to you parading and displaying itself as liberation, and you say, "Yes, I love you." And you are so innocent, you lack so much indiscretion that you totally forget to check and examine whether that which you are carrying home as liberation is actually liberation or something else.

You have never chosen bondage for yourself. Whenever you have chosen, your choice has been in favor of liberation. It's just that you have been pretty naive.

Love without wisdom means a lot of suffering.

Q: How can I distinguish whether I am following my Heart or my intuition?

AP: Test, just test. Be as cautious and wary of your intuitions as you are of other people. Rigorously, dispassionately just test. Examination is the way. Don't be biased in favor of your intuition.

Even your intuition is nothing but an internalized version of what comes from outside. If you start giving the opinions and dictates of others your consent, then after a time, you start feeling as if they are your own personal and original opinions.

What we call as our thoughts and our feelings are mostly not at all our own. Same applies to intuitions. Intuition too is just condensed experience, deep and frozen over time. Even animals have intuition, and intuition is of good help; intuition helps in physical survival.

But when it comes to the principle matter of liberation, then intuition is of very little help. And intuition has equally little to do with the Heart. Intuition too is a thing of the mind, just as thoughts and feelings are.

Thoughts are superficial, feelings are a little deeper, intuition is even deeper. And intuition is helpful. If you are in a jungle, intuition would help you. That's where the faculty of intuition really developed: in the jungle, when we were beasts for an unimaginably long time. Oh, we still are! That's when we developed the capacity to intuit and it was a very useful capacity. It saved us from predators. It helped men be synchronized to the ebb and flow of seasons. It helped men and women choose their mating partners.

In all those things intuition was helpful. It won't help you when it comes to your liberation. Just as you have to be liberated from thoughts and feelings, you also have to be liberated from your identification with intuition.

Unfortunately, even in spiritual circles, sometimes intuition is accorded a lot of respect; it does not quite deserve that respect. Testing and examination is the way. When one does not know what else can one do, look at the thing and then look at its consequence.

Christ once said, "The tree is known by the fruit." How else do you know if you do not look at the fruit? So, see what you do and see what it gives you. Make good use of your past and memories. There is no use

discarding and abhorring the past as something untouchable. The past is a useful resource, better use it.

See what you have done in the past so many times and see what that has given you. See what others are doing and what they are getting. You cannot afford to conduct all experiments upon your own only life, neither are you going to live long enough nor will you survive all the experiments. So, see what others are doing, look at them, read their stories, watch biopics, read biographies. Remain watchful.

Q: What is the difference between feelings and voice of the Heart?

AP: In the East, in fact everywhere in the spiritual domain, the Heart has not been taken to represent the center of feelings. It is the center of wisdom. The mind is taken as the center of all mental activity, and all mental activity includes both thoughts and feelings.

So, thoughts and feelings both emanate from the mind. Wisdom, realization, that's what the Heart is about. So, Heart has nothing to do with feelings.

Thoughts and feelings are one. If the mental wave is not strong enough, you call it thought. If the mental wave is quite strong, you call it a feeling. That's the only difference.

But because the mental wave is quite strong in the case of feeling, we succumb so badly to it that we start calling that wave as the ocean itself, and then we say the Heart is the center of feelings.

The worst defeat in front of feelings is when you start associating feelings with the Heart. That's when you have really kneeled down. That's the worst surrender. We have succumbed so totally to the force of feelings that we have started attaching divinity to them. And we have started saying, "Oh, thoughts come from here (*pointing towards the head*), feelings come from here (*pointing towards the heart*).” No, they don't. They both come from the same center. Wisdom comes from somewhere else.

Q: Is our life governed by our karma or is it run by destiny?

AP: It is totally governed by what you choose and what you do. Your destiny is destined, but your destiny can be made to wait forever. The destination is certainly there but what you do along the way determines your life. And what you do along the way is your karma.

So, no point entertaining oneself with the thought that destiny is preordained or that destiny is liberation itself. Destiny might be liberation, but look at your life. How liberated is your life?

The question is not what would happen at the end of the journey. The question is how are you doing along the journey. Life is the journey.

The destiny is well set and the destiny is common to everybody. Liberation is the destiny. But are you liberated right now? That's what matters.

Q: Then why have some people said that whatever is going to happen is already written?

AP: Those who have known have never said that. This would be said by only somebody who is very fatalist. If there is one thing that would inevitably happen, it is the end of all happening and that is liberation. Only that is certain and unavoidable, the utter end, the utter end beyond death. That is what you too want: the utter end of all this drama.

But is the drama anywhere close to ending for you? If not, then liberation is just a principle, and principles don't help. What helps, what is material, is the reality of life. Liberation is the final and unavoidable end and that would end time as well. But right now, see how your time is being spent.

Liberation which is yours to take has been postponed to distant future. Obviously, you cannot do away with it, you can merely postpone it. But see how far you have postponed it. And by postponing, pushing back liberation so far, we have turned the journey into a torture.

If one has to journey, can't one journey liberated? Can't you be liberated and continue to journey, just for fun? Why must you journey without liberation? But when you journey without liberation, you console yourself by saying that you are journeying towards liberation. It is such a bad consolation.

Why not journey with liberation? Why keep postponing your destiny? What great wisdom lies in thinking that destiny would come one fine day in the future? If it is inexorable, why not right now?

So, nothing is preset. You have free will; free will does exist. You better align your free will with your eventual and total freedom. Don't misuse free will.

What is the limitation of free will? It is free to go berserk. It is free to choose all madness. It is free to make all the wrong decisions. But it is not free to ultimately not be liberated. Ultimately, free will has to surrender to liberation. But how long would that take? That depends totally on you.

Hence, align your free will with freedom. Choose rightly.



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20.

Hear, concentrate, meditate, dissolve



itthaṃ vākyaistathārthānusandhānaṃ śravaṇaṃ bhavet
yuktyā saṃbhāvitatvānusandhānaṃ mananaṃ tu tat

‘To listen’, this is to pursue by means of sentences their import; ‘thinking’ consists in perceiving its consistency with reason.

~ Adhyatma Upanishad, Verse 33



tābhyaṃ nirvicikitse'rthe cetasaḥ sthāpitasya yat
ekatānatvametaddhi nididhyāsanamucyate

‘Meditation’ is indeed the exclusive attention of the mind fixed on (the import) rendered indubitable through listening and thinking.

~Adhyatma Upanishad, Verse 34



dhyātṛdhyāne parityajya kramāddhyeyaikagocaram
nivātadipavaccittaṃ samādhirabhidhiyate

‘Concentration’ is said to be the mind which, outgrowing the dualism between the meditator and meditation, gradually dwells exclusively on the object (of meditation) and is like a flame in a windless spot.

~Adhyatma Upanishad, Verse 35



Questioner (Q): You have said, “Intelligence is that which enables you to simply see. Intelligence is that which reduces the whole clutter and wipes away the dirt. Intelligence is your fundamental nature. Intelligence is the settlement of the mind. Live in intelligence.”

How do these activities of mind lead to its settlement? How does intelligence take over? What do these verses imply?

Acharya Prashant (AP): First of all, the translation is not quite accurate. That which is being talked of as concentration here is not really concentration.

If the topic of the course is Advaita Vedanta... I don’t know how the readings have been decided and which particular books are being referred to; in fact, why only Adhyatma Upanishad. I don’t know how the readings have been selected. If the topic is Advaita Vedanta, go to the principal Upanishads—Katha, Kena, Isha, Chandogya, Brihadaranyaka. I am not sure why these particular readings are being dealt with.

In the verses from the Upanishad that you have quoted, these four things have been talked of: listening, thinking, meditation, and concentration.

Concentration that is being talked of here is actually *Samādhī* (dissolution, union).

Listening that is being talked of here is actually just hearing. So, “Hearing is to perceive by means of sentences their import.” Hearing simply means: take in the sentence, take in the gross word, let the sound wave strike your eardrums, let your brain receive the signal. That is hearing. Let the sound wave strike your eardrum, let your consciousness receive the

signal that something has been communicated to you. That much is hearing. Obviously, hearing has to be there, without that things can't even begin.

Then there is thinking. So hear, then think about it. What does it mean to think? The Upanishad says, "To think is to measure the consistency of the heard sentence, the heard input, with reason." See whether what is being said is logical. See whether what is being said is factual. See whether what is being said abides by the law of cause and effect. See whether what has been said is self-contradictory. That is, then, thinking.

And then meditation is being talked of. "Exclusive attention of the mind fixed on the import rendered indubitable through listening and thinking." So, now that the heard word has passed the test of reason, so you believe in it, right? It has obtained for itself a certain credibility. You heard it, you examined it, you find it reasonable. So, it has some weight. Therefore, you can give yourself to it even more.

Meditation, then, is to concentrate on, focus on what that sentence is saying. And because all of this is being referred to in a spiritual environment, therefore the sentence that you are hearing obviously has Truth as its import. What else do you hear in a spiritual milieu? All sentences that deal with Truth.

So, Truth is the import of the sentence; meditation is the mind attending only to the Truth. So, a sentence about the Truth came to you. You first of all made yourself physically and sensually available to hear. If you are not physically available, if your ears are not open, then the beginning itself won't take place.

So, first of all you let the sentence be heard, then you critically examined the sentence, and you said, "At the level of reason, the sentence appears important, worthy, good enough to be taken forward," and then you meditate it. You said, "Right, the sentence is talking of Truth. What is this Truth? I see its importance, I see its total importance. How can I be available to it?"

And the more you proceed on this line, the more you find that you are insufficient. So, you give more of yourself to this process. Seeking the Truth demands all your resources. And when all your resources are demanded, then you withdraw your resources from elsewhere.

Pursuing the Truth is a giant enterprise. You will need to pool in everything that you have. So, you have to call back your forces from the various fronts they are deployed at. You will say, "You too come in, you too

come in. All of you are needed here. Something very important is happening here. You know, we are pursuing the Truth, and that requires everything that I have and much more.”

So, the attention is, then, exclusive. All your other affairs drop. You cannot be parallelly, simultaneously engaged with Truth and something else. If you are engaged with Truth *and* something else, then you will not have the energy to do justice to the Truth.

And in the competition between Truth and something else, the something else will always prevail. There is a clear reason: that something else is little, so it can survive even with your little dedication. That something else is small, mediocre, so how much attention does it need? Small, little. How much does Truth need? Everything.

Let’s say you have ten units of resources, and there is Truth and there is something else. Something else needs just one unit of your resources; it is small, frugal. Truth requires all ten units that you have. And you say, “Oh, I am greatly dedicated towards the Truth. I will give nine units to the Truth and one unit to something else.” In your own calculation, you have greatly favoured the Truth, have you not? You are giving nine units to Truth and just one unit to something else. You are saying, “You see, I love the Truth 9:1.”

But what have you actually done? That something else will survive because one unit is sufficient for it. Truth will die down. Your pursuit of Truth will be aborted, because Truth requires all ten. Even nine is highly insufficient. That little thing requires only little. Give it one—it will keep prospering. Therefore, the Upanishad says: *exclusive* attention. It cannot be Truth *and* something else.

Then, *Samādhi*. The duality between meditator and meditation is gone; the duality between the subject and object is gone; the duality between the ego and Truth is gone. The ego has become so enamoured of the Truth that it is prepared to lose its own identity. “I want That. I am looking continuously at That, so I have lost all track of myself. Do I exist? I exist now only in relation to That.”

So, first of all, the other relationships are cut off. You say, “I exist only in relation to That; That is my only identity. Who am I? Something related to That.” Everything else drops off. And slowly, you even stop saying that you are related to That. There comes a point when you say, “I am That.”

To begin with, how are you and what do you say? You keep saying, “I am related to this, I am related to that, I have a thousand relationships.” That’s the stage to begin with.

What happens when after hearing and thinking and meditation, you remain related only to That? The other relationships fall off. Because if you are to pursue That, then That requires everything that you have. If you give everything that you have to That, then the other things will obviously be disappointed, and they will all just get switched off and walk away.

So, now you have only one relationship. From hundred relationships you are left with one, and finally even that one relationship no more remains a relationship; it becomes a union. So, “I am not related to That. I am That.”

“I am related to the hundred, then I am related to just one, then I am the One”—that’s the process.

And then you have quoted me... Oh, forget it, it is not worth commenting on. I speak so much! So, it is already a bad situation. Don’t make me speak upon myself. It would be worse.



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21.

False concepts regarding mindfulness

(Rishikesh, 2019)



Questioner (Q): Acharya Ji, some teachers say that one should never forget that one is a watcher, and teach oneself to be mindful while watching, eating, sleeping, etc. Is it doable? What is its significance?

Acharya Prashant (AP): I just do not subscribe to this. It is quite harmful in fact.

The mind is already too eager to gather news from here and there, like a very suspicious old man, “What is happening? Where?” It needs rest, not more news, because any bit of news, any bit of information that comes to it would only be misutilized, and it already has millions or billions of terabytes of information. Could that do any good?

Isn’t it far better to just forget everything? Why add to your existing and overflowing repository of information? Just forget everything and be engrossed in rest. Ignore these things, they belong to the body, the body will take care of them—eating, walking, sleeping. If you start being observant about every step that the body takes, you will go mad.

Such advices have managed to sustain only because such advices have never been fully implemented. If somebody could actually fully implement these advices about watchfulness and mindfulness, then the dangerous nature of these advices would be exposed.

The mindfulness industry has managed to survive only because nobody can practically do what they are advising. If even one person can practically do what they are advising, he will prove the very debilitating nature of that advice through his madness. “He did it fully and he went crazy”—and that would be the end of these teachings.

But, fortunately for these teachings, they are so impractical, so crazy, that they can never really be implemented. Nobody can be so watchful about every morsel of food or every blink of the eye or every round of respiration. So, people just survive going mad.

And when they cannot implement these teachings fully, they feel that they are guilty and have therefore not benefited from the teachings. “I could not benefit from them because I could not implement them fully.” The bugger does not know that if he could implement them fully, he would go crazy.

The saint has never, never been known to be the one who is observant about these minor, microscopic things in life. The saint’s heart is elsewhere. He in fact ignores these tidbits called daily life. You look at his clothing, and it is possible that you might find that something is torn somewhere, and he is oblivious of it. He totally ignores these things.

He is carrying some utensil and the utensil has a hole. You become conscious of that hole, the fakir keeps ignoring that hole. Forget about ignoring the hole—if you tell him, “There is a hole in your vessel,” he will say, “Is there? Where? Where?” He is lost, he is somewhere else. That’s hardcore spirituality, not this.

There is the famous tale of Sohni and Mahiwal in Punjab.

So, Sohni used to cross the river using pots. They don’t sink, so she would use to float the pot and holding on to it, she would cross the river Chenab. One day some jealous woman kept a raw pot for her, not a properly baked one, an unbaked one. Sohni just picked it up and went to the river—and drowned and died.

That’s the Heart, that’s real love. You are so lost in your Beloved that you do not even bother to crosscheck about these things: What am I eating? What am I using for my physical defence?

The mindfulness industry would have said, “Oh! She is not mindful enough! That’s why she is going to die.” Obviously, she was not mindful enough, and that is why she was a lover. Who said that lovers are mindful?

Q: But then, why do saints put such high emphasis on observation?

AP: That observation is inner, not the observation of the food you take and the steps you put and this and that. The observation there is just this: “Am I with the Beloved or not?” There is just one thing that you have to watch out for. “It doesn’t matter where else I am. It’s either a zero or a one: one if I am with Him, zero if I am anywhere else. It doesn’t matter where I am.”

You are born with a purpose; the purpose is your primary concern. Otherwise, why are you alive?

You are born to get rest. You are born to get freedom from your restlessness. And therefore, that is what you must be fully occupied with.

That is your central mission.

*Everything else is incidental. Everything else is stuff worth ignoring,
not something you can afford to get entangled in.*



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